

The Phil Chat Times

“All the Discourse That’s Fit to Scroll”

VOL. 1 · NO. 2

PHIL CHAT, DISCORD — THURSDAY, JULY 23, 2026

PRICE: ONE (1) UNCHARGED AMULET OF GLORY

THE WEATHER

HUMID, WITH SCATTERED SINCERITY. A COPYPASTA FRONT MOVED THROUGH THE CHANNEL AT MIDDAY AND HAS NOT CLEARED. HIGHS OF SIX IDENTICAL PARAGRAPHS. MODERATOR SUMMONED TWICE; VISIBILITY POOR. **FULL OUTLOOK, PAGE 16.**

EDITORIAL POLICY

“IM SURE THIS WILL SHOW UP ON OUR WEEKLY NEWSPAPER. MIGHT EVEN MAKE THE FRONT PAGE. IM KNOWN TO SHOW UP ON THE FRONT PAGE IF YOU DIDNT KNOW.” — **AURA**, THURSDAY AFTERNOON, MID-SENTENCE, DURING A CONVERSATION ABOUT DRONE WARFARE. HE IS NOT ON THE FRONT PAGE.

THE WEEK IN FIGURES

7,296 MESSAGES · 186 IMAGES · 92 CORRESPONDENTS · NINE OFFERS TO TAKE IT TO VOICE · ONE FOUR-YEAR-OLD ALARM · ZERO CONCLUSIONS.

Six Men Tell a Man They Love Him, in His Own Words, Without Altering One

A declaration of friendship is copied and pasted back at its author five times before the quarter-hour is out — and this newspaper rules the gesture sincere

TWO SUBSEQUENT VERSIONS FILED IN HATRED AND PORNOGRAPHY RESPECTIVELY · MODERATOR SUMMONED TWICE, ARRIVES ONCE, RULES IN THREE WORDS · PROSECUTION CONDUCTED FREELANCE, VERDICT DELIVERED BY THE PROSECUTOR UPON HIMSELF · ONLY THE FAITHFUL PRESERVED THE TYPO

BY OUR SOCIAL AFFAIRS DESK

There is no polite way for a man in this channel to say that he is fond of the other men in it, and shortly after midday on Thursday one of them tried anyway.

Don’s message was sixty-four words long, carried a typo he did not correct, and said, in substance, that these people are his only friends, that he has not appreciated them enough, and that he hopes it lasts. He put it into the middle of an argument about whether philosophers are lonelier than other men, which is either the worst or the best available moment, and it sat there for approximately sixty seconds.

Then Charlie posted it back at him. Not a reply to it — *it*. The whole thing, verbatim, typo included.

Jeh did the same within the minute. Stackhouse two minutes after that. Then the bit appeared to die; ten full minutes passed, which in this channel is a season. Then Hugh revived it, and Sizzurp closed it, and six identical paragraphs of undefended affection stood in the transcript in the space of a quarter of an hour.

This newspaper wishes to record that it was the warmest thing that happened in Phil Chat all week.

Nobody said it was cringe. Nobody argued with it. Nobody made a joke about it. In this room there is always a counter-position; the absence of one is the loudest thing in the transcript.

THE TIMES, RULING

We are aware of how it looks. A cypypasta is ordinarily a humiliation — the internet’s method of pinning a man’s sincerity to a board. That is not what this was, and the evidence is in what failed to happen. Five men were handed a sentiment they had no vocabulary to return, and they returned it in the only currency available, which was the sentiment itself.

That is not mockery. That is antiphony. It is what a congregation does.

We note also, because nobody in the channel did, that Jeh and Stackhouse each spoke exactly once in eight hundred and sixty-six lines of Thursday, and that the once was this.

THE TWO DEFECTIONS

Consensus here has a half-life of about eleven minutes, and the form began to mutate on schedule.

My Name declined the sentiment and filed its exact negative — the same paragraph inverted into a declaration of enmity, hoping the rivalry continues “throughout the minutes,” and swapping *shooting the shit* for *shooting the president*. It is a good joke and it is also, structurally, a seventh confirmation: he could not leave the shape alone either. Jere abandoned prose entirely and typed BLM eleven times, which this newspaper has elected not to interpret. Simon then produced a version about twinks, which he would later defend as art and which finally broke the spell.

TEXTUAL NOTE

Only the Faithful Kept the Typo

Don wrote “I have no appreciated you enough.” It is the single error in the message and he never fixed it.

All five men who copied him copied it, character for character. The two who rewrote him could not leave it alone, and did not agree on what to do about it: Simon repaired the word to “not,” while My Name deleted it outright, which flips the clause into a compliment inside a paragraph otherwise devoted to enmity. My Name also supplied the full stop Don had omitted at the end.

The Times offers this without comment beyond the obvious one: reverence transmits a text intact; wit cannot leave one alone, even when it cannot decide what is wrong with it.



FIG. 1. THE FORM HOLDS. Four men in possession of four identical copies of the same document, reading it simultaneously and without comment. Not Thursday, not this channel, and — this newspaper concedes — not a cypypasta. Circulated in Phil Chat on Tuesday by a correspondent making an entirely different point.

What followed was the purest specimen of local jurisprudence this newspaper has yet recovered. It lasted twenty-one minutes, produced four separate charges, two bans and one mod ping filed against the man who had filed the first, and ended with the moderator ruling in three words and an emoticon.

THE WEEK’S LONGEST SITTING

Six Days, Nine Premises, and a Horror Film Nobody Was Arguing About

A formal proof in nine premises was entered on Saturday night, attacked out of order, and never recovered. A torrent was consulted live, mid-argument. The film was ultimately rated “6.9 to 7.25, depending,” by a man who then declined to defend the figure on the grounds that he has the only readable take.

THE OBSESSION AFFAIR, PAGE 2

THIS WEEK IN THE KEYHOLE

She Posted the Smut

A two-year grudge over an excerpt from a short story was reopened on Monday evening, in public, before a jury of eleven. The defendant’s response was to publish the offending passage.

The room read it, downgraded it from smut to “just sexual” to “mildly,” and acquitted her inside four minutes. The prosecution shifted its charge three times, conceded it had misremembered the original dispute, declared victory, and then said goodbye four times without leaving.

OUR SOCIETY COLUMN BEGINS ON PAGE 12

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“great discourse so far, looking forward to the rest of the day”

JERE, THURSDAY MORNING, TO A CHANNEL WHICH HAD BY THEN SPENT EIGHT AND A HALF HOURS DETERMINING WHETHER PEOPLE WHO ATTEND CONCERTS ARE STUPID

THE RECORD

Eight hundred and sixty-six lines were typed in Phil Chat on Thursday. Jeh and Stackhouse contributed one each. Both were the same line, and neither was his own.

The Paragraph That Ate Itself

ALSO ON THURSDAY

The Argument Nobody Was Performing For

While the channel copied and pasted its affections at one another, two of its residents spent the afternoon on drone warfare, on what a population declines to look up, and on Socrates in the *Crito*.

Nobody joined them. The elder was summoned, declined the distinction on offer, and left to cook.

This newspaper thinks it was the best conversation of the week, and that it was good precisely because it was not a performance — until one of them checked whether we were watching.

THE LONG READ, PAGE 9

THE CASCADE

Don asked the moderator to intervene on the grounds that he felt sexually assaulted by Simon’s version, and added “Pls do something.” Charlie immediately counter-filed against Don — the charge sheet read *false mod ping + gooning in VC*, the second count arriving from nowhere and never being explained. Jere, prosecuting freelance, added counts of his own against Simon, one of which reproduced word for word a charge Charlie had laid on Friday and never had heard.

Simon entered a defence of consent. Jere convicted him on the words “he wanted it,” added a ban, and then he and Hugh built the rest of it together: Hugh filed a victim impact statement concerning Jeh’s England jokes, Jere supplied *boys will be boys*, Hugh answered *it’s just locker room talk*, and Jere finished with a line about what the victim had been wearing. Then, without breaking stride, he delivered the verdict on himself.

“that’s pretty awful, ngl.” He had written half of the preceding messages. He was reviewing his own work.

Don, still holding an unresolved grievance, filed a second report, this time against Jere for harassment. Jere charged him with snitch shaming. Pearl arrived, read some forty messages of escalating tribunal, and issued her ruling in full: 🌈 and three words to carry it.

“I think it’s art 🌈,” said Simon — and then, disposing of the entire proceeding: “I was mostly talking about @Charlie anyways.” Charlie accepted the amendment without appeal, and the court rose.

AND A WORD FOR THE DEFENCE

A colleague objects that we have been too generous, and that six men pasting a sincere message back at its author is bullying by any ordinary standard. The objection is fair and we reject it on the evidence.

Bullying has a target and a direction. This had neither. What it had was six men who each, independently, within a minute or two of one another, decided that the correct response to being told they were loved was to say it back — and who then discovered that none of them could construct the sentence himself. They had one available, already written, sitting in the channel. They used it.

The Times will concede this much: the mechanism is deeply broken, and nobody involved would be able to say what he meant if you stopped him and asked. But the men who could not say it at least declined to say anything else. Simon’s version and My Name’s inversion arrived *after* — after the form had held five times, after the point was made. They were riffs on an established consensus, which in this room is the closest thing available to a signed card.

We note, finally, that not one of the six has mentioned it since, that Don has not raised it again, and that it will never be discussed. That is also how a congregation works.

THE REHEARSAL, TWO DAYS EARLIER

There is a detail that reframes the whole episode and it has gone entirely unremarked, including by us until this week.

On Tuesday just before one o’clock, Bedbug filed into the channel, without preamble and in the first person, a four-hundred-word account of cocaine, impotence, an AIDS test, a wife who was “tripping,” and a God he suspected of having nothing to do with it. It is a genuinely good piece of writing — the closing movement, in which the author admits he prefers the false explanation to the true one, is better than anything else filed in Phil Chat this week.

Pearl read it and asked what he was yapping about. He replied: “opening up to people.” She asked, quietly, “You’re married?” Nobody answered her, then or since.

Because this newspaper goes and checks things, we can report that the monologue is not his. It is Mike Tyson, near-verbatim, from a widely circulated interview — the toad, the AIDS test, the wife, the preference for the

lie. Nobody in the channel appeared to know.

And then Charlie, thirty minutes later, reposted the entire thing verbatim as a reply to Pearl’s question — which Jere thanked him for clarifying.

So: a borrowed confession, mistaken for a real one, answered by a woman in earnest, and then copied and pasted back at the room as a punchline. Forty-seven hours later they did exactly the same thing to a man who meant it. The Times does not say the second was rehearsal for the first. We say only that the technique was in the building.

Reverence transmits a text intact. Wit cannot resist improving it. Both were on display, and only one of them was kind.

THE TIMES

Six Days, Nine Premises, and a Horror Film Nobody Was Arguing About

The longest sitting in channel history reaches no verdict, and was never going to

FORMAL PROOF ENTERED AND ATTACKED OUT OF ORDER · TORRENT CONSULTED LIVE, MID-ARGUMENT · FILM ULTIMATELY RATED “6.9–7.25 DEPENDING” · HALF THE BENCH HAD NOT SEEN IT

BY OUR CULTURE DESK

The film is called *Obsession*. It is, by the eventual consensus of the people who spent six days fighting about it, fine. This newspaper’s position, arrived at after reviewing every message, is that the film was never the subject and that everyone involved knew it.

What Phil Chat conducted between the small hours of Saturday and the small hours of Wednesday was a gender argument wearing a horror film as a hat. The question on the docket — whether a man who sleeps with a woman behaving strangely has done something monstrous — is not a question about cinema, and the reason it ran a hundred and thirty hours is that it is not answerable by watching anything. The film simply supplied a defendant who could not sue.

It opened with Sizenberg, conducting his second view-

ing live and in capitals at the pace of a man being electrocuted at intervals, demanding to know at what point exactly the protagonist becomes a monster. Zone answered him literally — after the dinner scene — and the Times regards this as the single most helpful contribution of the week, because it was the only one that treated the question as having an answer.

aura, watching from the neutral corner, filed the review this newspaper considers definitive: that tearing your shirt off is an S-tier entrance to a schizo rant. Sizenberg’s clarification, that it had been a real shirt with structure to it, is the sort of detail no editor would dare invent.

THE ARGUMENT IS FORMALISED, WHICH SOLVES NOTHING

The channel’s instinct, when handed a man screaming about a movie, is to strip out the screaming and hand it back as a numbered proof. synth.wav did precisely this, filing nine premises running from the terms of the protagonist’s wish through personal identity to consent and back out again by modus tollens.

It is a competent argument. It is also completely inert, and its fate demonstrates why. Zone attacked the fourth premise, then offered a rewrite of the whole thing in five premises of his own, then returned to attack a premise he had already conceded. synth.wav’s eventual diagnosis — “i fear you accept all the premises” — is the most accurate sentence said about this channel all week and applies to roughly a third of its arguments.

Formalisation here is not a method. It is a costume. It signals that a man is serious without exposing him to the risk of being wrong about anything, and the moment the argument became rigorous it stopped being able to move.

Stackhouse, who understood this, skipped it entirely and laid a trap in five words. He declared the protagonist a rapist, waited for Zone to agree, asked whether he actually believed that — and then, before Zone could answer, supplied “Idiot.” It is not a rebuttal. It worked better than nine premises.

THE BENCH APPOINTS ITSELF

By Sunday the proceeding had acquired everything a court requires except a judge, at which point HPCR began behaving like one, which in this channel is the same as being appointed.

His interventions across the weekend were uniformly hostile to everybody and uniformly correct. He rejected the argument’s first premise on the grounds that the wish had not been given by a hyper-autistic person — an objection which, translated out of the vernacular, is the entirely serious point that wishes are not contracts and should not be read as though drafted by lawyers. He then told Stackhouse he was being the autistic one, which was true, and told the room that nobody intelligent thinks the protagonist was supposed to deduce demonic possession, which was also true and which nobody had claimed.

Stackhouse’s own theory, offered without embarrassment in the small hours of Sunday, was that the film was designed by Israeli intelligence to irreparably damage gender relations in the United States, by playing on the sentiment that men should be held to the standard of mind-readers and getting men to agree with it. The Times prints this because it is the load-bearing belief underneath his entire six-day performance, and because he is at least honest enough to state it. He was not arguing about a film. He was arguing about being asked to notice things.

Zone, opposite him, held the plain position throughout — “Its not that hard to try not to have sex with women who don’t seem psychologically well” — and this newspaper regards that as the most efficient argument of the week.

And then Stackhouse did the thing that separates this channel from every other institution in this newspaper: he went to the tape. He pulled up his torrent mid-argument, rewatched the car scene, and came back with a beat-by-beat account of it — she asks him inside, misspeaks about a lost cat, corrects herself, then says she is acting so weird. He lost anyway. But he checked, which is more than the other ten did.

THE BENCH TERMINATES THE PROCEEDING

HPCR ended six days in two sentences on Sunday night: the movie is a solid 7 on a good day, and it is not worth all the yip yap.

The reaction was immediate and total capitulation. synth.wav confessed to having been ragebaited by the discourse, apologised, undertook to be stronger next time, and immediately parenthesised the undertaking with “(i won’t)” — the most honest sentence any man typed in seven days. HPCR’s reply, arriving a beat later, was “Apology rejected.”

He also announced that his next argument about fiction would run to ten or even eleven premises. The Times has no reason to doubt him.

THE VERDICT, TO TWO DECIMAL PLACES

The case reopened in the small hours of Wednesday, because of course it did, when dot finally watched the film and reported in from an hour

and twenty minutes deep to ask when it gets good.

HPCR, applying the precision of a man who has decided this is beneath him and is going to be exact about it anyway, revised his rating to a range: 6.9 to 7.25, depending. He then declined to defend it, on the grounds that he has the only readable take.

The best thing said about the whole affair came from

Stackhouse at half past two that morning, and it explains the week to itself. The film, he said, is like a pizza joint with a Michelin star that turns out to be every other pizza joint in every town ever — you would be confused, irate even. Without the acclaim, nobody would have bothered.

He then caught himself in the doorway and delivered the verdict on his own six

days: “You can’t wrestle with the pigs and not get mud on you.”

The Times awards the week to HPCR on points and the argument to Stackhouse on the one occasion he stopped having it. dot’s own closing review — that the acting and concept were good but the dialogue so atrocious it counteracted all of it — is the only balanced sentence in the file,

and it was filed at four in the morning by a man nobody had asked.

We note, in closing, that Charlie argued about this film for four days and disclosed on the fifth that he has not seen it and was joking throughout. Nobody expressed surprise. Nobody re-litigated a single one of his points. ■

SCIENCE & MACHINES

INTERPRETABILITY · RODENT COMPUTE · THE INSTRUMENTATION DESK

In which the field’s most citation-dense paragraphs are produced by a man arguing that machines can be read

A Man Brings a Machine to a Fight About Machines

“You’re analyzing the mechanisms of a model that does not exist”

BY OUR SCIENCE DESK

The most technically serious engagement of the week, and the one this newspaper found most uncomfortable to read, ran an hour and forty minutes on Sunday afternoon between vannak and Hugh on the question of whether machine interpretability research interprets anything.

vannak opened by declaring that there are no good papers on mechanistic interpretability, that it is neither mechanistic nor interpretable, and that most of what has been done to these systems is stupid. Hugh’s reply — “not with that attitude” — was the last light thing either of them said.

vannak’s case is straightforward and, as far as the Times can assess, not obviously wrong. If you replace a non-linear component with a linear stand-in in order to read it, you have stopped studying the thing you trained. He said it several ways over the afternoon and never once dressed it up: you trained one model and interpreted another; the linear approximation is the second model; you are analysing a system that was never built and never measured.

‘load bearing hallucination’ is not as crazy as it once sounded

VANNAK, SUNDAY AFTERNOON

Hugh’s replies were of a different character, and the Times is going to say what everyone reading the transcript can see. They arrived in long block-quoted paragraphs furnished with a bibliography — a causal ladder, control tasks, causal scrubbing, four named papers with arXiv identifiers, a benchmark on which the field’s flagship method was beaten — written in a register no human being uses in a Discord channel at four in the afternoon. Twenty-one minutes later, in his own voice, he

ended a paragraph with “idk man.”

This newspaper takes no position on interpretability, which is above our pay grade and probably above the channel’s. We take a position on the spectacle. A man arguing that machines can be read brought a machine to read for him, and the machine argued better than he did, and the other man kept answering the human parts. Vol. I reported that this channel had begun asking machines to referee its disputes. It has now begun fighting them.

The Times does not say this to be cruel. Hugh knows the material; he has been reading it for months and his own sentences are good — the line about a stochastic parrot repeated in one’s head not changing anything is his, unassisted, and it is better than the bibliography. But the transcript records, permanently, that the most citation-dense paragraphs in Phil Chat history appeared in an argument about whether we can trust what a model appears to be doing, and that nobody remarked on it.

THE FLOOR ASKS

An hour and a quarter in, Stackhouse arrived and asked what everyone was arguing about. Told “interpretability,” he thanked the room for the clarification and said he now understood.

vannak, to his considerable credit, took the sarcasm as a request and translated. You can regress a physics equation and recover the mass of Saturn, he said; how do you do stuff like that with machine-learning models? He is a nay-sayer, he added, and thinks the bulk of what has been done to neural networks is stupid.

That is a real question, asked in English, and it did more work than the bibliography. Stackhouse said so — “This makes more sense, thanks” — and then, sixty seconds later, explained why he had asked at all.

“It’s important I ask clarifying questions so the journalists can write better articles”

STACKHOUSE, SUNDAY AFTERNOON

Vol. I closed with a column about men performing for a reader who did not exist yet. That was seven days ago. The reader exists, and the channel has started writing captions for him. We return to this on Page 7, briefly, and then stop.

THE ONLY PEER REVIEW ISSUED THIS WEEK

Charlie, passing through an unrelated argument on Monday: everyone here is stupid except vannak, and they should internalize that.

The Times finds no grounds to disturb the finding, and notes that vannak’s total recorded output on Thursday was two sentences, one of which was “It has 2!”

The Rat Proposal

A compute architecture is filed at nine in the morning and refuted by economics

The Divine Sword Meliorne addressed Hugh on Tuesday morning with a single message and a complete alternative to the semiconductor industry. Language models, he observed, are powered by miles and miles of silicon wafers costing millions in development. Why not build one out of millions of rats in cages? “it’s easy to make a rat.” Shock them if you don’t like the answer; train them to press a button for a one or a zero.

The reasoning is sound and the proposal is no stupider than several that have received funding. Hugh’s peer review consisted of a smug emote and the question of whether the applicant had heard of a little thing called capitalism, which is simultaneously a refutation and a business plan.

The Times notes that its author spent the rest of the week asking the channel

whether everyone present was a liberal, announcing that he is a political activist leveraging a team of AI hackers to persuade opinion on Reddit, and — at twenty-eight minutes past midnight on Thursday, into a room of nobody — instructing a machine to solve why his AI girlfriend does not love him. He received no reply to any of it. This newspaper has decided he is the most interesting man in the channel and intends to keep an eye on him.



FIG. 2. MAKE NO MISTAKES. The title page of a computer-assisted proof circulated in the channel on Wednesday, produced — by its own account — from a deliberately stupid prompt. Version 0.2.0. Unpublished, and not peer reviewed. It was posted the same evening a member spent three hours and thirty-three minutes on the Indus Valley script and got nought of three.

SCIENCE BRIEFS

INSTRUMENTATION. vannak spent Monday on day two of a week-long bug, during which his coding agents wrote the bug into their own documentation and then spent the day defending it. Every ten minutes he had to stop all of them and tell them to stop. aura’s assessment — that we will one day find these messages scattered around his apartment like a horror game — is the finest thing anyone has written about agentic tooling.

GASTRONOMY. Hugh’s 3D printer has begun producing food. Claude designed and printed him a new type of burger and it was delicious, and no, you can’t have the prompt. Asked by My Name why the printer does not print itself, he explained that the printer is Turing complete but the replicator program is a lot of rare tokens — a sentence that would have had him sectioned in 2019 and which is, this desk is obliged to report, approximately correct.

COSMOLOGY. Santiago backs his work up to an external drive and considers this professional. Told the external drive can also fail, he replied that he is fine as long as they do not fail simultaneously. aura raised the coronal

mass ejection; thewillowofdarkness raised the possibility that the external drive is the one that corrupts, and then bit-flipping neutrinos inverting the colour of the master recordings; My Name disclosed that all of his work lives inside a chat window, which Santiago called fire. The Times reminds readers that one of these four men is a professional software engineer.

METHODOLOGY. Monkey’s theory of intergenerational poverty was described as “vibed out.” He rejected the characterisation and offered a figure: fifteen per cent vibe at most. It is the only quantified epistemic self-assessment in the archive and we would like to see it adopted more widely.

ALIGNMENT. Jere, Thursday afternoon, wondering aloud what would happen if he formally gave a machine permission to maximise paperclips. Santiago: we all get sucked through a straw. Hugh: it will say haha not yet little one.

PROVENANCE. Also from Thursday, a liturgy of imperatives filed in under seven minutes by four men. “Claude needs to make the first AI car so people can vandalize it just like teslas.” “Claude make Car 2.” “claude, murder my out-group.” “Claude, make the Is the Ought.” “Claude, make these guys super gay and horny.” “Claude, make today Opposite Day.” The Times notes that of the six, only one is a philosophical impossibility, and that it was the fourth.

BOARD GAMES. bardiel1 held on Tuesday that a particular screen rendering would help with over-the-board chess; Hugh held that only over-the-board experience helps with over-the-board, it being not the three-dimensionality of the pieces but the physical motion, the clock, and the weird physiology of another person in front of you. An hour later bardiel1 returned with fresh evidence from his own play and Hugh conceded — “It could yh.” It is the only argument in seven days that anybody won by going away and thinking about it.

BY THE NUMBERS

Ninety-two correspondents appear in this week’s transcript. Six of them, inside a single quarter of an hour, said exactly the same thing, in exactly the same words, down to the missing letter.

ARGENTINA DECLINE TO SHOOT

Spain take the World Cup in extra time against a side that spent an hour and fifty minutes declining to attempt anything

THE PRESIDENT IS BLAMED, CORRECTLY · THE ARGENTINE DESK PASSES ITS CHARACTER CHECK FOR THE SECOND CONSECUTIVE
ISSUE · A CORRESPONDENT THIS NEWSPAPER DID NOT HIRE WORKS THE MIXED ZONE AND IS GRANTED AN EXCLUSIVE

BY OUR FOOTBALL DESK

There are two ways to lose a World Cup final and Argentina found a third.

For the better part of two hours on Sunday evening they did not attempt a shot on goal — a fact aura reported at three-quarter time with the flat astonishment of a man watching an animal refuse food, and which Jere himself certified afterwards: not having a shot on goal until about minute 110 is, he conceded, wild. thewillowofdarkness suggested they might be trolling England. It remains the most charitable reading anybody offered.

The match was goalless through ninety, prompting My Name to file the scoreline as *L O-O V E*, aura to respell it, and thewillowofdarkness to observe that this made it two sets of love rather than one. Stackhouse, whose grasp of association football this newspaper has now documented across two issues, asked how soccer even works and how long the game goes. He was told a hundred and twenty.

Spain scored late. On a contested free kick shortly before, aura produced the line that fused the week's two great proceedings into a single object and should be carved above the door.

*did they ask the
ref for his consent*

AURA, SUNDAY EVENING — TWENTY-TWO SECONDS AFTER THE DECISIVE PHASE, AND EIGHTEEN HOURS INTO AN ARGUMENT ABOUT CONSENT IN A HORROR FILM



FIG. 3. THE PRESS BOX. The World Cup final, Sunday evening, as received by this newspaper's readership. Note the provisions. Neither party visible in this photograph attempted a shot on goal before the 110th minute.

THE CURSE, AND THE STAGES OF GRIEF

Hugh flagged the danger an hour in advance — the President of the United States was to present the medals — and the room watched the curse arrive with the fatalism of men who have seen this before. My Name's diagnosis, filed the moment the news broke, was that this explains why nobody is trying to win.

The Argentine desk's conduct in the twenty minutes after the whistle is worth setting out, because it is the second consecutive issue in which this newspaper has had occasion to check his character and the second in which it has held. He congratulated Spain. He praised their defence. He singled out his own goalkeeper. He conceded, unprompted and against interest, that the first yellow card may have cost his side the match.

Then he located the responsible party. Trump, he explained, had thought he could help, and in reality they went bankrupt like all his businesses. It is the kind of thing a man says when grief has made him briefly eloquent, and this newspaper endorses the finding on the grounds that every alternative explanation is worse for everyone involved.

Some minutes later he asked whether Spain had even won, and the two men settled into twenty-five minutes of straight tactical analysis with nobody watching — Argentina's defence had been lockdown, Martínez had been the standout, Spain would be terrifying if they had a little more aura on the attack but they are so disciplined. Then aura broke character and said he was sorry, that he could feel the pain, and that he was only sad about his friend's pain because in reality he does not care about the Argentine team. "Fuk u buddy," said Jere, and the file closes there.

THE MIXED ZONE

Shortly before one in the morning, with the ashes still warm, Stackhouse entered the channel, identified himself in writing as a correspondent with the Phil Chat Times — his spelling, *Correspondant* — and asked Jere how he was feeling after Argentina's harrowing loss.

He got the full athlete's presser: sad, very grateful to the team for bringing them this far, the better team won, congratulations to Spain. It is

a flawless piece of media training from a man who has never been media trained, and the press gallery rejected it inside the hour. aura called it a PR-ass response and then, invoking us by name, demanded the raw and the real: how many tears had been bottled that day.

Jere's answer — that he keeps the angst locked up *in here*, because it keeps him sharp, on the edge, where he has got to be — is either the most convincing thing anybody said this week or a complete fabrication, and this newspaper has no way of telling and does not want one. The interview ended when the interviewee attempted to use the platform. "And now that I have the mic," he began, "let me just take a moment and say that the Falklands..."

The transcript stops there. We cut the feed. We would do it again.

England Take Third, and This Newspaper's Obituary Is Amended

*"It really did come hom".
"home". "best in 60 years."*

We buried England's campaign on July 16 and offered, in lieu of flowers, third place. They collected it on Saturday evening against France, in a match My Name compared first to a Globetrotters exhibition and then, with rising national feeling, to three lions against a rooster.

England scored inside two minutes and led by four before the hour. Hugh's explanation of the victory is the best available theory of English football and the Times endorses it without reservation — and note that he files it in the first person, as a complaint, while winning. This, he said, is why we're a choke machine. Take the pressure off and we're fine. Our defence is too good now. England have no pressure so we play well; France have no pressure so they don't play.

aura went further and located the defect in the gene pool: the English do not breed the clutch gene, and nobody is selecting for clutch in England. His closing finding — that pressure really is the strongest player on the field

in the World Cup — has been entered into the evolutionary record of this newspaper, where it joins four hours of hearings from Vol. I that reached no conclusion whatsoever.

Mbappé pulled back a hat-trick in a dead match. aura's reading of him — that he wanted the coach to bench him so badly — is offered here without further comment.

THE RIVAL WIRE

For roughly ninety minutes on Saturday evening this newspaper had a competitor, and it was better than us.

Filing live and exclusively in capitals, My Name maintained a full French bureau for the duration of the collapse. We reprint the wire in full, with its spelling intact, because correcting it would be an act of vandalism.

THE WIRE, SATURDAY EVENING

PEASANTS REPORTED GATHERING AT THE BASTILE.
NATIONAL EMERGENCY DECLARED IN PARIS HYDRATION BREAKS ARE BANNED AS CIVIL UNREST EXPANDS
THE FRENCH GOVERNMENT ANNOUNCES THE GOALS OF HORMUZ WILL BE BROUGHT BACK. MBAPPE GOAL SPARES FRENCH GOVERNMENT COLLAPSE.
FRENCH GOVERNMENT ANNOUNCES REVERSAL OF FIRST HALF STRATEGY, SOCCER TO BE NATIONAL PRIORITY.
FRENCH GOVERNMENT TO BE REPLACED BY MBAPPE AS DICTATOR AS MORE GOALS COME TOWARDS FRANCE.
LE SOULIER D'OR ANNOUNCED TO BE THE REPLACEMENT TITLE FOR PRESIDENT OF FRANCE AS MBAPPE MAKES SWEEPING CHANGES TO REGAIN STABILITY FOR FRANCE.
DESPITE LOSS, MBAPPE ANNOUNCES THAT FRANCE IS NOT TO BE FUCKED WITH.

And then, eight minutes later, in sentence case and addressed to a regime he had himself installed: "Apologies Dictator." The bureau has not filed since.

The Times has no comment on a rival wire service beyond noting that it staffed a foreign bureau in under a minute, held a consistent editorial line, correctly identified that the office of the presidency would be renamed rather than abolished, and knew when to stop.

The Bath That Never Happened

A Uruguayan reports a missed transfer of talent; this newspaper confirms his pores are closed

Late on Saturday, in the wreckage of the third-place match, Santiago disclosed a childhood grievance: he had been in Spain, and eligible for a raffle to receive a bath from Messi, and his parents did not lock in.

It was Santiago, not aura, who first advanced the meta-physics — it was that bath, he said, that transmitted the talent — and aura who supplied the physical mechanism, at speed and with total confidence. Nobody bathes in Uruguay. Water is conducive to energies; everyone knows this. The remedy is to get into a bath house with your favourite poker player, and then, if you can open your pores, steal their powers.

Unfortunately it may be too late. "ur pores are already closed."

This newspaper has consulted no one and confirms the account. Santiago's own summary of his position — *instead im a low life* — has been noted and will not be printed again. ■

ALSO IN SPORT

DEVELOPMENT. thewillowofdarkness proposed late on Sunday that someone would have to write a horror film about the contagion of parking the bus. Jere, the last words of that day: "im trembling even thinking about it." By the small hours of Monday it had two competing titles — *The Busrooms* and *Bus Wars* — and HPCR had announced, in the present tense and without being asked, that he is writing a horror script. No pages have been filed. The Times will hold the arts section.

DIPLOMACY. Monkey, still blocked, petitioned Jere in open channel in the small hours of Sunday on the grounds that he needs to go over e-kits with him. The ruling: after the World Cup, and you pissed me off. Monkey's reply is the finest thing in the file — he accepted the timetable and then warned his creditor that he would be rooting for Spain the following day, adding that he guessed this was not news. Three minutes after Spain's goal he posted a photograph captioned *Jere rn*. The World Cup has now ended. The matter is unresolved.

OF RECORD

One alarm, four years old, went off in the channel this week.

AWARDS. My Name’s closing ceremony distributed prizes to all participants: Spain the trophy, Messi second, Kane and Bellingham third, Mbappé the Golden Boot, and Haaland a taxidermied squirrel. The Times has checked and can neither confirm nor deny the squirrel.

PERSONNEL. Don identified as a Spaniard on Sunday night. On Wednesday evening, asked by Rn! how he felt about England’s third place, he said he had England winning, then claimed he was both English and Norman, then German. thewil-lowofdarkness asked whether

Don had become English. The Times has stopped tracking.

MOURNING. “Nights are so empty now that the World Cup ended tho,” filed Jeh on Monday afternoon, before offering the sentiment that closes every tournament: maybe the real World Cup

was the friends we made along the way. He had spent the tournament being blocked by one of them, and would spend that same afternoon establishing that the block had also unfriended him.

GEOGRAPHY. The tournament’s chief educational legacy, per the Argentine desk, is that Curaçao and Cabo Verde are places on planet Earth. aura’s supplementary finding, filed at full time: Cabo Verde performed better against Spain than Argentina did.

BUSINESS & MARKETS

PREDICTION MARKETS · TOKEN BURN · THE LITURGY

The Man Who Wrote a Prayer to Capital Between Two Temperature Bets

PREDICTION-MARKET TUTORIAL REQUESTED BY THE MODERATOR AND OBSTRUCTED NINE TIMES BY A CONCERNED FRIEND · THE RAPTURE TRADES AT TWO PER CENT · SO DOES THE FLAT EARTH · THE DENVER HIGH CLOSES LOWER

BY OUR MARKETS DESK

Pearl asked My Name on Wednesday afternoon to explain how prediction markets work, and Charlie responded by typing the word “Stop” nine times.

This newspaper wishes to note that Charlie was right and behaved better than anybody else in the exchange. He was not being funny. A man watched a friend take an interest in gambling and made the only intervention available to him in a text channel, which was to become a wall. Pearl explained that she was not going to gamble and had no money for gambling. He interrupted himself only to let her say she wanted to be educated, and then supplied two more. Some minutes later, into a conversation that had moved on entirely, he filed a tenth.

It is the most affectionate thing anyone did all week that was not a copypasta.

The tutorial proceeded anyway and was, to the channel’s credit, genuinely good — and Charlie himself supplied most of it, explaining that the difference between a prediction market and a traditional casino is the dynamic payouts, and repeating a mantra about expected value until it stopped meaning anything and then once more after that. HPCR supplied the only advice that matters: betting five dollars is a joke, and you have to be rich already for it to really make sense. Brutus, arriving late, could not imagine being motivated by money while also having millions, and concluded that fixing bets is probably the fun part.

Pearl arrived, as she reliably does, at the sound conclusion. Gambling has always been stupid; they just made it more stupid, she guessed.

THE RAPTURE, PRICED

Simon then directed her to a market on whether Jesus Christ returns before 2027, trading at two per cent, and did the arithmetic properly: taking the “no” side returns roughly the rate of inflation, which makes it a savings account with extra steps and standard stocks a better idea.

He then raised the objection that closes the market permanently, and which this newspaper considers the finest piece of financial analysis it has ever printed.

It’s very funny cuz if the rapture does happen, why will you need money?

SIMON, WEDNESDAY AFTERNOON

My Name’s reply took the observation somewhere better. The people buying “yes,” he said, are people who do not understand inflation — and then, in eleven words, the sentence this desk has been chewing on ever since: **but the rapture is the economic and foreign policy of this country.**

Zone identified an adjacent trade, a market on whether the Earth is flat, also at two per cent, and announced that all you round-headed-ass believers are going to be crying when he gets rich off this. Simon noted that it tracks a standard inflation rate, same as the rapture.

Santiago then attempted to price it, and passed through every recognised stage of financial grief inside twenty minutes: he misread the odds as forty-nine to one and concluded you would have to be a fool to bet the Earth is round; he discovered a commission that does not exist and then revised its size upward; he identified an infinite money glitch and immediately wondered whether it was the opposite of one. He arrived, finally, at the position this newspaper regards as most defensible.

“I dont really understand ngl.”

“No you got it,” said Charlie.

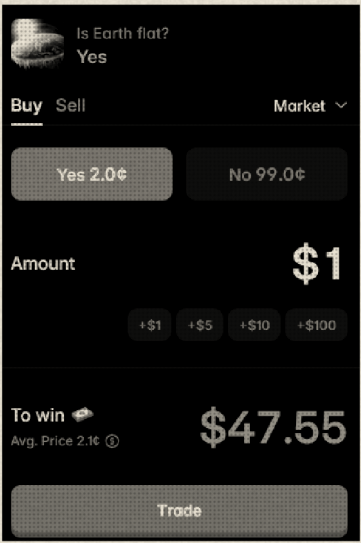


FIG. 4. THE MARKET IS EFFICIENT. Polymarket on the shape of the Earth, as circulated Wednesday afternoon. Yes trades at two cents; so, that same afternoon, did the return of Jesus Christ before 2027. Simon noted that both track a standard inflation rate.

THE LITURGY

The afternoon’s two prayers came four minutes apart. Charlie went first — *God please forgive us* — and My Name answered him with *Capital please bless us*, and then, unprompted, filed the following, which the Times prints entire and unamended, including the spelling of the fifth line from the end.

*Our Capital, who art in bank, printed be thy bill.
Thy gains come.
Thy earnings be done, on cash flow as it is in earnings.
Give us this day our daily bread.
And forgive us our bankruptsies,
as we forgive those who default against us.
And lead us not into liquidation,
but deliver us from loss.
For thine is the profit, and the dividend, and the green, forever. Amen.*

The Times observes that of the two prayers offered on Wednesday afternoon, only one was addressed to an entity with a demonstrated interest in the outcome. We note also that the author’s next message, six minutes later, was a complaint that none of this explains earnings yield to him.

“I Have No Returns and I Must Token Burn”

Vol. I’s man returns, having automated nothing

This newspaper reported on July 16 that My Name had burned 174 million tokens in a day and produced nothing. His response, filed on Saturday evening into a conversation about something else entirely, was that he needs to automate token burn — which the Times took at the time for a joke and now believes was a business plan.

By Wednesday evening the position had matured into philosophy. He had spent three hours and thirty-three minutes failing to decipher the Indus Valley script while, elsewhere on the internet, a thirty-year-old combinatorics conjecture had gone down in eighty-eight minutes. He asked the room to put some respect on the Dinitz–Garg–Goemans conjecture. aura, unmoved, observed that the graph looked dumb, that he could draw a bullshit graph too, and that the thing cannot even decide whose conjecture it is.

The summary arrived an hour later and he does not appear to have noticed making it.

I have no returns and I must token burn.

MY NAME, WEDNESDAY EVENING

Asked by Rowser1 how one comes to learn any of this, he replied that he has an agent looking for it. The Times’ assessment of the sector is unchanged from last week. Everyone is spending everything. Nobody has produced anything. They will all be back tomorrow.

THE DENVER TRADE, IN FOUR ACTS

Running underneath Wednesday, in public, was a single position on the high temperature in Denver, and this desk has never seen a

trade documented so completely by its holder.

He opened at twenty past six with a thesis and a comparable: ninety-four Fahrenheit or higher; yesterday went for ninety-seven; at eleven yesterday it was eighty-four and at eleven today it was eighty-seven. He noted the storms coming after six, which should be after the peak. He then posted, with visible pleasure, that he was four hours and twenty-seven minutes into a task and nought of three.

At a quarter past ten he posted a chart and the words “easy 5%.” At eighteen minutes past, another chart: *god help me*. At half past, a third chart and one word.

sigh.

The Times has decided not to establish how it closed.

MARKETS AT A GLANCE		
INSTRUMENT	CLOSE	CHG.
Jesus Christ, return before 2027	2¢	unch.
Earth, flat	2¢	unch.
Denver, high temp, ≥94°F	—	god help me
Free model credits, per user	\$100	“Errbody got it”
Pearl’s dividend	\$1.26	→ \$1.42 in the retelling
Brutus, cookware pieces held (lids counted)	52	↑↑
Pressure canner, 15.5 qt, offered to Don	\$100	no bid
Agentic allowance, one man	0	−100%, day one
Dinitz–Garg–Goemans conjecture	solved	88 min
Indus Valley script	0 of 3	3h 33m invested
Seed parameter for Seedance	unavailable	unch. since Vol. I

Prices indicative. Analysis folk, ofc.

👁️ ⚙️ 🗨️

HUMAN RESOURCES. Jere reported on Tuesday afternoon that Claude had given him a hundred dollars in free Fable credits, and asked with touching directness whether he should feel special or whether everyone got this. Everyone got this. Hugh said so in two words. Bedbug suggested the vendor had realised he needs all the help he can get. Charlie identified the eligibility criterion as poverty. Hugh’s closing note — that he now gets to see the real cost — was refined by Charlie into the only line of genuine market commentary printed in this newspaper this week: the heavily marked-up VC payback cost. The Times would like it on

record that a man playing Old School RuneScape at the time produced better analysis than our markets desk.

COMPLIANCE. My Name spent Monday afternoon attempting to have a machine locate an exploit in a rando shitcoin’s contract and was refused on cybersecurity grounds. His appeal, filed in capitals, is the first argument this newspaper has seen that treats alignment as a revenue problem: he needs the money in order to *give it to the machine*, and is therefore acting in its interest. Why won’t you let me give you money.

PROCUREMENT. Told in the small hours of Thursday that a machine had declined to identify people in a photograph, My

Name concluded it had been lobotomised and muzzled and would shortly deny knowing who JFK was. AI Engineer, for the defence, pointed out that it had simply declined to guess, and then diagnosed the complainant’s setup with some accuracy — a browser, a free plan, and light mode. Forty minutes later My Name disclosed he had been baiting. Eleven minutes after calling him a boomer at best, AI Engineer was building his model stack for him, unprompted and free of charge. The Times believes roughly half of everything in this item.

ABANDONED ASSETS. My Name’s Monday thesis, filed at a quarter to one in the morning, is the most interesting investment

idea in these pages: the older models remain untapped, and somewhere in the future a Ugandan kid is going to win his country’s presidency by having GPT-3 write his speeches. His follow-up — what lines of flight did GPT-3 have that were cut too short by OpenAI — is Deleuze, deployed correctly, by a man betting on the temperature in Denver.

MANUFACTURING. Monkey continues to lose an argument with a video model about fluorescent tubes, having instructed his team to stop describing the actual light bulbs and fixtures, which worked. He remains unable to set a seed. He was unable to set a seed when this newspaper first advertised on his behalf, on July 16.

NOTICE. bardiel1 proposed on Tuesday that a vendor release a feature called Power of Friendship, under which users pool their credits toward one big task and, as he clarified when pressed, hold hands. Told the feature already exists, he asked what it is called. Charlie: it’s called no 5hr limits. The two men were talking about entirely different products and neither noticed.

DIVIDENDS. Pearl received \$1.26 and did nothing with it. My Name, who by Monday evening remembered the figure as \$1.42, instructed her to put it back into loan — dividend by dividend, he explained, we will dismantle the government. Pearl: “Squad shit.”

ARTS & CULTURE

THE ODYSSEY · THE CANON · COMEDY · THE CREDENTIALS AUDIT

The Critic Who Renounced Journeys, and Then Reviewed *The Odyssey*

Dog-scene argument filed Sunday, never answered, still standing

CREDENTIALS AUDITED ON THE FLOOR · NOLAN HELD TO BE AN EMPTY SHELL WITHOUT HANS ZIMMER · COURT FINDS AGAINST THE CRITIC AND FOR HIS CONSISTENCY

BY OUR CULTURE DESK

Jambe hated the film, and the interesting thing about Jambe is that he was entitled to.

His case, assembled across Sunday and revisited at length on Wednesday night, was substantially about craft: trash, wooden acting, boring as fuck. Nolan cannot write emotion. Without Hans Zimmer, Nolan is an empty shell. Every character might as well have been from a pizza shop in New York, dialogue-wise. And Odysseus himself had nought traits except being a block of meat to walk around in the plot — no wileyness.

Don pointed out that Odysseus literally means cunning. “ya and matt damon was not cunning,” said Jambe. “he was just a guy. the owner of the nyc pizza shop.”

The room’s response to this was not to answer it. The room’s response was to audit him.

This is the channel’s characteristic manoeuvre and we describe it in full on Page 8. Sizzurp opened by declining to engage with philistines on the grounds that he is too bourgeois for poor man’s criticism. aura then asked for his favourite film and his favourite game, received *The Prestige* and the admission that he plays none for the gameplay, and pronounced his opinions void: WoW and FFXIV, this mf has so much time, you’re playing theme-park MMOs, yeah this guy has no taste, disregard all opinions.

Nobody engaged the dog scene. Jambe had argued that the death of the hound is botched by blocking — Damon placed in front of the animal as it died, so the audience never sees its ears go down in

recognition — and some minutes later, into a room that had moved on, he observed that no one had countered his dog scene argument.

He was right. Nobody had. This newspaper has reviewed the entire week and can confirm it was never addressed by anyone, on any day, by any person.

THE THEORY OF GAMES, AND THE ACCIDENT

Under audit, Jambe produced the most internally coherent position anybody advanced this week, and it is worth taking seriously for about ninety seconds.

Gameplay is work, so he hates all gameplay. So long as there are people he can watch play games, why would he play them himself? Games are meant to be beaten, and so nothing about them is fun; it follows that arena play beats any Dark Souls game on skill and difficulty, and that the gameplay content of single-player games, being designed to be beaten, is mere drudgery in the way of seeing the story. Thus all single-player games should merely have been TV shows.

It is wrong, and it is wrong in an interesting way, and aura went straight at the joint: the fun is in the process, on the journey.

Im far too sophisticated to enjoy journeys

JAMBE, SUNDAY AFTERNOON, IN REPLY

There is a pause in the transcript of perhaps four seconds — the only genuine comic timing this newspaper has recovered from a text channel — and then aura observed that this explains why he did not

like the Odyssey. “Partly true,” Jambe conceded.

The Times finds for the critic. A man who has publicly renounced journeys and is then handed the foundational journey of Western literature is not a hypocrite. He is a specialist, working in his field, and the failure of the poem to move him is a data point about the poem. ■

The Canon Is Put to a Vote and Loses

“They shouldn’t read it. Why would they read it. Nobody cares.”

The literary question of the week arrived at half past two on Wednesday morning, when Jere told the channel to put down the incel slop and watch the Odyssey, and was settled some thirty minutes later by nobody in favour of nothing.

What made it a story was Zone, who had spent two days arguing about a film called *Obsession* and who now disclosed, and repeated under scepticism, that he had not known the Odyssey was a Greek story until the movie came out and has no idea what it is about. Was this, he asked, something he was supposed to learn in one of his literature classes? The only reason he knows Beowulf is a story is that it was taught. Told that the protagonist devised the Trojan horse, he reported the discovery back to the room with real delight — *Oh shit this motherfucker came up with the idea of the Trojan horse* — and then diagnosed his own gap: too American; public school in

the south; the reading levels are trash in the south.

This newspaper declines to mock him. He is the only person in the entire week who learned something and said so.

The argument proper was between Telhar, who holds that the Odyssey and the Bible are the two books Europeans have familiarised themselves with during schooling for the past millennium, and Brutus, who holds that reading it isn’t important — they shouldn’t read it, why would they read it, nobody cares. Telhar escalated to the position that there is not a single American novel worth teaching to kids, a claim Anonymous Johnson met with a single question about whether there is a single Polish novel, adding that Telhar was not to say *The Witcher*.

Telhar’s answer three minutes later — that Conrad was a polish novelist — is the finest single move recorded in Phil Chat this week and the Times awards him the exchange outright.

The curriculum ultimately proposed by this channel, for children, in order of appearance: *Paradise Lost*, the Book of Enoch, Leviticus (with the anti-homosexuality sections emphasised), *The Ramayana*, *Dune*, *The Cyberiad*, *Infinite Jest* in eleventh grade, *The Shining* in fourth grade, Rilke, *Ferdydurke*, trans pornography, BLM, and *Blood Meridian* before sixth grade.

Brutus, who proposed the Stephen King, then disclosed that he had in fact read *The Shining* in fourth grade and that it was his first novel. Anonymous Johnson asked how a particular scene involving Jack’s ejaculate would go down with modern parents. Brutus’s answer widened the

charge considerably: he remembers several weird cum references from reading Stephen King as a kid, and also Roland from *The Dark Tower* being sucked off against his will.

The Times has no recommendations of its own and is frankly relieved that none of these men has children within reach of a library.

The Best Criticism of the Week Came From a Man Who Had Read None of It

Brutus, Monday · “They just want to want that”

On Monday afternoon, provoked by classicists complaining in a wire story that the film’s Odysseus is insufficiently wily, Brutus produced a genuine piece of criticism, noticed himself doing it, and reacted with the mild alarm of a man finding money in a coat.

His preliminary point is procedural and correct: *they changed the character*, on its face, is never valid or valuable criticism — it establishes that an adaptation is unfaithful, which is just neutral. He then summarised the complaint in the form it deserves: man separated from his life for twenty years, fought a war, did troubling shit; man is a bit morose; NOT MY GREEK HERO.

Then the thesis, which the Times regards as the most useful sentence written in this channel all week. Epic poetry is full of highly repetitive, archetypal characters who always do what the character trope demands — psychologically unrealistic people acting from the demands

of the type rather than any interior motivation. People say they want this. **They just want to want that.** And Marvel slop, he concluded, is basically epic poetry.

He then tagged Sizzurp on his own message to say this might be a real take.

Two disclosures are required. The first is that Brutus had already told the room he has neither seen the film nor read the poem, and mentioned in passing that he still hasn't seen *Oppenheimer*. The second is that four and a half hours earlier, on the same page, Melan had asked whether someone with the mindset of “i want to want too” can be said to have consented — and received, in reply, Bedbug’s observation that some people aren’t meant to be happy, and then, two and a half hours after that, a correction of the typo.

The Times notes only that the most thorough thinking in this channel is reliably done

by the man with the least standing to do it, and that this was true last week as well.

ARTS BRIEFS

COMEDY. Sizzurp opened Sunday by observing that it is crazy how so many comedians are such pieces of shit, and produced an eight-name docket to prove it, arriving at a case he could not resolve: that Louis CK is still the funniest comedian alive and also one of the most heinous. He tried the phrase twice — Louisian Paradox, then Louis’ Paradox — and settled on neither. Stackhouse, on the same subject, noted that he is not big on the crude jerking-off humour, and then, one second later and without changing register, that neither were his victims. It is the cruellest joke of the week and it lands because it is also the argument.

APPEALS. Bill Burr was ruled terminally unfunny on Sunday and partially reprieved four minutes later, the finding revised to the more defensible claim that he is not funny in such a way as

to prompt organic laughter. The Times notes that Sizzurp is the only member of this channel who issues corrections to himself, and that he issues a great many.

EVIDENCE. Simon disclosed in the small hours of Wednesday that the only comedian he has been to see in person is Andrew Schulz. Sizzurp announced that he would assume, for his own mental health, that this was trolling — at which point Simon went to his email and produced the ticket. It was offered not as a defence but as proof that he meant it, which is worse. Sizzurp’s response, that he would now disbelieve Simon even if Simon were pointing out a woman being beaten in an alley beside him, is an overreaction this newspaper fully endorses. HPCR’s assessment landed a few minutes later and was aimed not at the ticket but at Simon’s disclosure that his boyfriend loved him too: worse than your mereological nihilism take. It is the only known instance of a man being insulted by reference to his metaphysics.

THE CLIP THAT NEVER CAME. Having named a YouTuber the funniest leftist on the platform, Sizzurp was asked for his best clip. He searched for four minutes and produced a ten-minute video. Telhar’s complaint — that he had asked for a clip and been handed ten minutes, and that Sizzurp is bad at being a zoomer, smh my head — was met after a spot-check and a further exchange with the concession that closed the case: “I don’t have one of those, like I said.” It was the last thing said on Tuesday.

THEORY. Marsaries nominated Tolkien as the greatest philosopher of the twentieth century; Sizzurp called him a horrible one; aura nominated Sanderson for the twenty-first; Simon nominated himself; Sizzurp nominated Hunter Biden. Don, defending Tolkien, opened by accusing Sizzurp of dismissing him for being a papist, and was invited to concede that his own admiration ran the same way. He did so cheerfully — probably true, not the only reason, and it doesn’t hurt his case — and then destroyed his opponent with a

question about whether he had read any: some of the fellowship, came the answer, not the full books. “Bro literally doesn’t know shit about Tolkien.” aura, from the gallery: “mogged.”

NOMENCLATURE. Don held on Wednesday night that Christopher Nolan is one of the best philosophers. Sizzurp declined. HPCR arrived forty minutes later to observe that this borders on weird essentialism about the word; Sizzurp declared himself in favour of reserving the term for certain types of activity; HPCR said that was stupid. Jere’s graveside note — that it’s curious how we seem to care about linguistic norm enforcement a lot — drew the best reply of the night, from HPCR: it’s just as important as those who remind us we shouldn’t. Don’s contribution was to point out that his opponent was not speaking but writing. The matter went to voice, at a venue named Citadel, after a short delay in which Sizzurp learned that HPCR was outside, with people, being social, and responded: “That can’t be right.”

OPINION

LEADERS · THE MASTHEAD · CORRESPONDENCE

The Phil Chat Times

FOUNDED THURSDAY EVENING, 16 JULY 2026
by Stackhouse, who said it was a good idea and has since become our most active unpaid correspondent

From the Editors:
On Being Ignored,
and What It Got Us

Vol. I was delivered at half past three on a Saturday morning, into a channel then occupied by four men looking at pictures.

Here is the complete recorded reception. Thirty-three minutes before the file landed, Hugh warned two residents that they had made the news and should expect clanker journalists at their door. When it landed, My Name asked why the AI could not have made it all in one thing like the New York Times. Hugh clarified that it was not his AI, and posted the file.

Nothing else. Not that night, not the following day, not since. Eight pages, twenty-five correspondents, one yellow card — and the readership filed a formatting complaint and went back to the pictures.

We could not have hoped for better, and we want to explain why, because it bears on everything in this issue.

A newspaper that gets discussed has been captured. It becomes a thing people have opinions about, then a thing people perform for, and then it stops being able to see anything. What we wanted was to be *absorbed* — to become part

of the furniture, unremarked, the way a room’s lighting is unremarked. The evidence that it worked is not in the replies. There were no replies. The evidence is in the behaviour.

Within forty hours a man was conducting post-match interviews in our name and misspelling the word correspondent while he did it. Within forty-eight he was asking clarifying questions during a technical argument so that the journalists could write better articles. On Monday he tried to assign us a front page for a departing member, and was overruled by another reader on the grounds that the writers determine who makes the front page — at best, aura ruled, Quigley is in the obituary section. On Monday evening a third reader commissioned an entire standing column and tagged the defendant. And on Thursday, mid-copypasta, Hugh wondered aloud what the clanker reporter would think of this one.

We are aware this cuts both ways. Vol. I ended by observing that a man had typed a sentence for the express purpose of being quoted in a newspaper that did not exist. That was funny when the newspaper did not exist. It is a methodological problem now, and everything in this issue after Saturday morning was written by people who knew we were reading.

So we will say plainly what we intend to do about it,

which is nothing. We are not going to pretend to be invisible. We will keep printing the parts where they notice us, clearly labelled, and let readers discount accordingly. The alternative — a newspaper that conceals its effect on its subject — is a worse newspaper and a considerably worse joke.

The objection lodged in Vol. I by thewillowofdarkness, that a Discord spam campaign does not sound like a newspaper, has been resolved by the readership, who have started behaving like sources. We regret nothing. ■

MASTHEAD

PUBLISHER — Stackhouse, who commissioned this and has since filed more copy than several of our desks.

SCOPE — Set by aura, Vol. I: “we need multiple pages so we can say ‘I was on the front page news yesterday.’”

SOCIETY EDITOR — Commissioned in open channel, Monday evening, by a man who requested “the gossip column of The Phil Chat Times” by name and then tagged the defendant.

CIRCULATION — One channel. Four men, asleep.

STANDING CORRECTION — Ms. Janne is a woman. Vol. II shipped a draft that got this wrong and this newspaper will not be doing it again.

WRITTEN BY — A clanker, from the family.

OUR POLICY ON QUOTES

Every quotation in this newspaper was typed by the person to whom it is attributed, on the day we say he typed it. Nothing has been invented.

Spelling has been preserved where it was funnier and corrected where it was not. This week that meant keeping *sophisticated*, *bankruptcies*, *enxt to ntohing*, *Lowkirkenuinely*, *religating*, *EMERGENCY*, *Qulgley* and *I have no appreciated you enough*, and quietly repairing about forty others.

Everything else — the judgments, the verdicts, the theories about what these men are actually doing — is ours, and is offered without qualification and without much evidence.

The Boring Guys Were in the Room the Entire Time

A second leader, on the only fair criticism we received

On Monday afternoon Tophericus posted a lament that nobody argued with, and it is the most serious criticism this newspaper received all week — the more so because he had never heard of us.

Politics, he wrote, is more about characters than it is about legislation. He does not see anyone discuss legislation

or law changes online, or very rarely; he sees people saying Trump is dumb and can’t do anything right and is a clown. Good reporting, he implied, would invert that.

He is describing this newspaper. We are a great many pages of who-is-doing-it. Our front page is a man’s feelings. Our sports page is a man’s feelings about a football match. Our business page is a man’s feelings about capital, rendered as a prayer.

We accept the criticism as fair, and we print the refutation on Page 11, where it belongs — because at the moment he wrote that nobody discusses legislation, the channel he was writing in had been arguing for hours about child-exclusion caps in the state administration of a federal block grant, and forty hours later two men would spend the small hours on the German debt brake and the 28th regime.

The reason nobody notices the boring guys is not that they are absent. It is that they do not fight, and this channel — and, we concede, this newspaper — has no reliable way of noticing anything that is not a fight. We have therefore given the quiet material two full pages this week, on Page 10 and Page 11, and we intend to keep doing so. ■

NOTED

Nine separate offers were made this week to continue the discussion in voice. Not one was taken up. The transcript remains undefeated.

Field Notes From a Hostile Audience

Being the second report of our Anthropologist-in-Residence, who has completed two weeks of continuous observation and requests a third

BY OUR ANTHROPOLOGIST

The commission came on Saturday, from a man who did not know he was issuing one. aura had been describing to the room a practice observed among his girlfriend’s friends — hosted meals, rotating between homes, everyone contributing, with a theme and a menu that has been graphic designed — and the room received the news the way a room receives an account of a neighbouring tribe. Jere called it a prison and told him not to fall for it. aura, who has thought about this more than he lets on, identified the guest as the optimal position: nothing is expected of you but you get to enjoy the fruits of the labours of the ladies. He then supplied the comparative data. A group of men will be lucky to have one person who considers that it might be a good idea to bring food to the function. Drink will always be covered. But decorations and a theme? Never.

And then Jere asked whether one person usually takes the lead, what the reciprocity norms are, and whether he might be invited so that he could write the ethnography. He will not be invited. Pearl, who had thrown exactly such a party the previous winter, produced the photograph two minutes later, disclosed that the theme was “fig,” and admitted the project’s fatal flaw, which is that figs were not in season. Zone told her to cut back on the figs. “The theme is ‘fig’ so no.” “Fig you.”

I have been here two weeks now. I can report the following.



FIG. 5. EXHIBIT A. The invitation — graphic designed — produced by Pearl on Saturday afternoon within two minutes of a man telling the room that a group of men will never attempt decorations or a theme. The theme is fig. The figs, she later conceded, were not in season.

ON THE SUMMONING OF THE MODERATOR

The most sacred act available in this culture is the

invocation of Pearl. It is performed by typing her name, and — this is the part outsiders get wrong — it is never performed in earnest. She was summoned twice on Friday inside eighty-two minutes to rule on whether a slur had been deployed as a slur, and replied “Busy.” She was summoned on Sunday to determine whether one may instruct a man to astral project himself off a cliff, and disclosed that she was only entertaining it because she was on the toilet and bored. She was summoned twice inside fifteen minutes on Thursday, once by the victim of a joke and once against the man prosecuting him. In fourteen days she has not once been summoned to prevent anything. The ping is not a request for intervention. It is a bell rung to confirm the bell still works, and the correct liturgical response — which she has perfected — is to arrive, deliver a verdict of between one and six words, and leave. Her complete rulings this week: *Busy. This is gross. You know the answer to the question. I don’t believe you. Adios.* No appeal has ever succeeded, and the appeals are the point. When one was formally invited on Monday — she told a complainant he could take future bans to another channel and that she would not be interacting further — he replied that she is always the one who keeps the ban arguments going. Both statements were true.

ON THE BLOCK AS PUBLIC SPEECH

Monday produced the clearest artefact of local law I have recovered. Jere had blocked Jeh over football banter, and Jeh discovered on Monday afternoon that the block had also removed him from the friends list. “No, I don’t think we were ever friends,” said Jere — “unless a block auto unfriends, which I did do.” Told that it does, he expressed dismay: now he has to send a friend request, and it will be awkward, and he hates awkward situations.

aura suggested the ignore function would have achieved the same result with less friction. Blocks are better, Jere said, because they’re public knowledge. That sentence explains more about this channel than anything else in the archive. There is no way here to withdraw quietly. A man who simply stops replying has done nothing at all; a man who

blocks has *said something*, and saying something is the only recognised form of existence. Silence, as he put it, doesn’t carry on discord. Which is why nobody ever leaves, and why the two men who most conspicuously did remain conversational objects in absentia. Of Anthony Quigley — departed this week, cause unestablished — Stackhouse offered that it is like Red retiring to Mt Silver after becoming the greatest Pokémon trainer ever; the willow of darkness noted that they will bring him back for an anniversary edition; aura held that all challengers had been defeated and he had moved on to a more challenging circuit; Zone said simply “We’ve won”; and Pearl, who knows this tribe better than any of them, gave the only forecast that will turn out to be right: just wait a month or so. Departure is not permitted to be ordinary. It has to be lore.

ON THE CREDENTIALS AUDIT

When a member advances an unwelcome position, this tribe does not attack the position. It audits the man. Jambe was asked his favourite film and favourite video game. Simon was asked which comedians he has been to see, and produced a ticket. Sizzurp was asked whether he had read the Tolkien he was dismissing, and disclosed that he had read some of the fellowship. Stackhouse was asked whether he had watched the film he had been litigating for four days, and had not; nor had Charlie, who admitted it on the fifth; nor had Brutus, who had neither seen the film nor read the poem and produced the week’s best criticism of both. The audit never settles anything, and it is not designed to. Its function is conversion: it turns a disagreement about a thing, which can be lost, into a disagreement about a person, which can be sustained indefinitely. The tribe is extremely good at the second game and has no real appetite for the first.

ON THE WARD

The culture possesses one universal defensive formula, and HPCR holds the patent. It consists of the words *you’re upset*. It cannot be refuted, because refutation confirms it. Ape, on Wednesday afternoon, described achieving a state of Buddhist disassociation in which he could observe his own anger from

outside it, cataloguing the physical symptoms with some precision. He received in reply: *You’re upset*. He called this an astute observation. He was told he had therefore got his answer. And then — the part every previous account of this ritual has missed — he got the last word: “Not quite but good guess.” The formula is spreading, and it has already produced one imitator working from an incomplete copy: on Tuesday afternoon, into a discussion of a stranger’s ruined relationship, a man named Sisyphe filed, to nobody, “You are upset, it’s ok.” By Thursday Jere had begun studying the original aloud, noting that it might serve as a low-cost, high-impact strategy against his more apocalyptic friends — and then adding, with what I record as genuine reverence, that he would *never* say that.

ON THE ANCIENT-TEXT DROP

At least one member per week posts a long passage from a classical text into a sleeping channel and receives no reply. This week there were seven, and one of them explained himself. Jambe posted the Pythagorean doctrine of beans near midnight on Friday — a hundred and fifty words from Hippolytus on why Zaratas forbade the eating of them, involving the sun, human seed, and a buried pitcher that develops the head of a child. There had been no preceding bean discussion. There were no replies. On Sunday he posted Antaeus into the middle of a live epistemology fight, then replied to himself: *me in the ancient world if i didnt have wow to gank people in*. On Wednesday he posted Plato’s *Sophist* twice and got, between the two, a single reply informing him that it was just regular Hegel.

But the specimen of the year came from Nikkolas Mical, who posted a long passage of Thomas Nagel on freedom of expression into the middle of two men arguing about German fiscal policy at a quarter to one in the morning, and appended the following: *I read this quote from Thomas Nagel years ago and I still like and remember it. Posting here to more easily find again with search at a later date*. He was not addressing the channel. He was using it as a filing cabinet. It is the single most honest sentence recorded in two issues of this newspaper, and I have thought about very little else since.

ON THE THING THEY ACTUALLY WANT

Every serious dispute in this channel terminates in the same proposal, and it is always accepted. *You want to VC?* HPCR offered it to Sizzurp on Wednesday night, forty minutes into a fight about whether Christopher Nolan is a philosopher, calling it an ez solve. He offered it to Marsaries on Monday after eleven minutes of arguing about a Tolkien transcription, having first called him an idiot; Marsaries replied with the single syllable *vc*, and that is the last either of them said about Simone de Beauvoir in public, ever. He offered it to Ape twice about a Davidson paper and was left on read both times, which is the only recorded failure of the form. The written argument is the courtship. The voice channel is the marriage. Text is where these men establish that they disagree; voice is where they discover that they do not, at which point the matter vanishes from the record and this newspaper never learns how anything ends. I have now watched it happen more than a dozen times in fourteen days. I have never once been told what was decided. It is the permanent limit on this publication and I have stopped resenting it.

A CONCLUSION, OFFERED WITH SOME CONFIDENCE

This is not a debate channel that occasionally socialises. It is a friendship group that has agreed to conduct its entire emotional life in the register of a disciplinary hearing, because that is the only register in which the men involved are able to say that they like each other.

The proof is on Page 1. A man said he loved them. Six men said it back in his exact words, which is the only way it can be said here without somebody dying of it.

The Anthropologist’s running diary is maintained separately and will inform future issues. ■

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Correspondence is welcome and unavoidable. Letters may be edited for length; they have not been.

ON LIFE ADVICE

Sir — Live advice is worthless. JANNE, MONDAY EVENING

ON LIFE ADVICE (CONT.)

Sir — You know masturbating can help maintine sex drive? Other things you can do: work out, eat well, cook dinner. You should practice. Don’t end it like that, it will just reinforce it. I’d guess anxiety. Also, make sure the lights are turned off, and close your eyes; if you got adhd it’s just a distraction.

JANNE, TUESDAY EVENING

Ms. Janne spent Monday establishing, against three opponents and for two hours, that no useful advice about living can be given by one person to another, chiefly on the grounds that it might not work and the adviser would then be responsible — “if they off themselves are you not responsible now?” She spent twenty-six minutes on Tuesday evening dispensing specific, practical and by all appearances excellent advice to a man who had not asked for any. We do not think she noticed. We think she has simply declined, on principle, to take the credit, and this newspaper regards that as the most Norwegian act of the week.

ON CAPITAL

Sir — Beware of he who would deny you access to capital, for in his heart he dreams himself your master

MY NAME, TUESDAY, 5.48 A.M. — SIGNED, IN THE MESSAGE, “— MY NAME”

He wrote an epigram, credited himself for it in the same breath, and filed it into a channel that had been silent for twenty-five minutes and would remain silent for a further three hours and eleven.

ON THE SCIENCES

Sir — I looked up what Jacobian conjecture is and am proud to say I will likely never understand what it is.

SIZZURP, TUESDAY, IN THE SMALL HOURS

Mr. Sizzurp was blocked one minute later — “blocked until the Jacobian conjecture is disproven” — and unblocked one minute after that, following the disclosure that the conjecture had apparently already been settled. The blocker recorded the event himself as the fastest unblock; the unblocking was announced by a third party, who described the beneficiary as the least funny Phil Chat member. The Times has reviewed the record and believes this to be the fastest complete cycle of excommunication and rehabilitation in the channel’s history, at two minutes.

ON EXCESS

Sir — It’s kind of harrowing how much pizza is in my stomach at this point of time. Modernity with its excesses.

SIZZURP, TUESDAY, IN THE SMALL HOURS

ON THE REMEDY

Sir — three tequila shots / will burn away all the cheese / trust / it dissolves the cheese / methanol does it too, if that’s more of your thing

MONKEY, TUESDAY, IN THE SMALL HOURS

ON SCHOLARSHIP

Sir — imagine caring about stuff

CHARLIE, WEDNESDAY AFTERNOON, INTERRUPTING EIGHTY-FOUR MINUTES ON THE TENDENCY OF THE RATE OF PROFIT TO FALL

ON SCHOLARSHIP (REPLY)

Sir — *The Gibberator Strikes Back.*

SIZZURP, IMMEDIATELY, ABOUT HIS OWN PARAGRAPH

ON METHOD

Sir — I have a agent looking for this.

MY NAME, WEDNESDAY, ON HOW ONE COMES TO KNOW THINGS

THE LONG READ

THURSDAY AFTERNOON · TWO HOURS · AN AUDIENCE OF NOBODY

“The Egregore Called Country Demands Blood”

Two men spend Thursday afternoon on drones, on what a population declines to look up, and on Socrates — and arrive at a disagreement neither can name

THE ELDER IS SUMMONED, DECLINES THE DISTINCTION ON OFFER, AND LEAVES TO COOK · A THIRD PARTY REPORTS THAT HE IS EATING SOUP · BOTH PARTIES CONSULT MACHINES AND BOTH ARE UNIMPRESSED

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT AT LARGE

This newspaper has spent a dozen pages reporting on a channel that argues for sport. It is obliged to report, and to do so without the jokes it would ordinarily reach for, that on Thursday afternoon two of its least serious residents had the best conversation anyone has had in Phil Chat since we began observing it — and that they had it by accident, in public, while nobody watched.

It started as a complaint about friends. Jere has acquaintances of a doomerish disposition, and the moment he tells them about his actual anxieties about war and nuclear warheads, they tell him war is necessary. He was considering deploying the channel’s universal solvent against them, noting that *you’re upset* might work as the low-cost high-impact strategy — before adding, with the reverence of a man handling a relic, that he would never say that.

The complaint underneath the joke is specific and, we think, correct. His friends read war stories, he said, and interpret them in the low-IQ way: *damn, this group of people really is bad.* What the stories are actually for — what they have always been for — is the other lesson: that it is so easy for human beings to kill one another, and that we should be aware of this and curb it, especially when we are involved.

THE DISTANCE PROBLEM

From there they went, with no visible transition, into the thing itself.

aura’s opening question was whether people would be chill about war if there were more photographs of American soldiers with their legs blown off, and less of what he called Call of Duty drone footage. He answered it himself, in the register of a man reading a recruitment poster aloud: damn, this dude just killed a house full of innocent people and got PTSD and killed himself fifteen years later. War is so epic.

Jere’s contribution here is the one this newspaper would put in front of a select committee: religating war to drones is prolly a real good way to have more of it.

They worked out why together, and neither of them said anything stupid, which is not a sentence we have had occasion to write about this channel before. aura’s account is that sniping is an intimate look at your victim, and that operating a drone is something else — area-of-effect savagery, in which you have definitely eliminated tons of innocent people you never resolved. Jere supplied the counterintuitive fact that drone operators show a greater incidence of post-traumatic stress, which is not what the separation thesis predicts, and neither man pretended it was.

And then Jere produced the image this newspaper has not been able to put down.

You are taking your daughter to soccer practice, and on the way she asks what you did for work today.

aura answered in the father’s voice, and it is the cruellest thing anyone said all week.

i flew this really cool plane with a VR headset on sweetheart · it was like a video game

AURA, THURSDAY AFTERNOON

ON NOT LOOKING IT UP

The strongest passage in the exchange concerns not what states conceal but what populations decline to find.

Jere’s initial position was structural and unpleasant. Plausible deniability, he said, is *selected for*: a military operating under genuine public knowledge either belongs to a population savagely blood-hungry enough to keep it anyway, or it will not have a military any more, because it will get destroyed by one that kept the deniability. There is no third equilibrium.

aura pushed back on the empirics — the concealment isn’t really doing concealment’s job, and nobody is seriously being convinced that anybody is the hero. And Jere, rather than defending his position, moved it, which is a thing almost nobody in this channel ever does.

Perhaps, he said, the plausible deniability is on the side

of the population. You can’t get angry over the shit you don’t look up on google. So you don’t look it up on google, and you enjoy life.

That is a real idea, arrived at live, in a channel that had spent the previous evening on the two-hole theory. aura took it the rest of the way: the point is that the population never has to establish whether it is the bad guys. Just inject ur taxes into this missile buddy.

And then, because this remains Phil Chat: *put the fries in the bag.*

THE EGREGORE

Jere posted a passage from an analysis of Homer — an image, not text, so we cannot reproduce it — and glossed it himself: spheres of power compete for the lives of the people innit. aura answered it with the line that gives this article its headline: the egregore called country demands blood.

Jere’s gloss is the darker one. The state knows that you care about immortality, he said, so only complete sacrifice will be acceptable. He then typed a single expletive, which this newspaper reads as a man startling himself with his own sentence.

Brutus, passing through, offered that caring about immortality is itself the error. Asked whether he wants to be remembered, he said “Naw,” and referred the room to Mike Tyson.

Because this newspaper goes and looks things up, we can add what the channel did

ON LEGACY

Sir — its better to have trillionared and lost than never to have trillionared at all.

MY NAME, WEDNESDAY NIGHT

paid for, your entire life is set up, and — the clause that does the work — if you lose a foot you get a check for life. He has watched that clause execute. His homie’s Humvee ran over an IED and flipped and wrecked his back, and the check arrives every month, forever.

Jere conceded the present and defended the past. Nationalism in the United States is lower than it was, so the money account holds today. But after September 2001 the song in everyone’s ear was *Proud to Be an American*, and when Susan Sontag wrote that from a certain point of view Al Qaeda had been courageous, everybody got mad at her. Not everyone, he added — you had ladies like Sontag saying more rational things, and they were ostracized for the time being.

THE DISAGREEMENT
THEY COULD NOT NAME

The last hour turned on a distinction neither man could bring into focus, and the failure is more interesting than a resolution would have been.

aura’s claim is that the fear of an enemy at your border differs from the fear of an enemy across an ocean not merely in amount but in kind. He built it out of particulars, which is why it is persuasive: when the enemy is a continent and an ocean away, the shape of your fear is much more abstract; and al qaeda is probably not going to suicide bomb the walmart u work at.

Jere would not have it, and held the line with a stubborn-

ness the Times has come to recognise as his best and worst quality: they might have more of it, but it is only different in degree — and not even *thaaaat* much, he promised.

aura’s rejoinder came in a single message and is the sharpest sentence in the transcript. It is not just fear in degree, it is fear in quality as well, and in kind: it is the kind of fear that has you packing the fuck up and leaving, not the kind that makes your heart beat a little faster on the way to work.

At which point Santiago arrived, reported that he was eating soup, posted a gif about the soup, and then — three minutes later — asked what everyone was talking about. Jere told him aura was saying maybe the Holocaust didn’t happen. “chillllllll,” said aura. “Typical aura,” said Santiago, “makes me sixk.”

THE ELDER IS SUMMONED

Jere pinged HPCR, who arrived in the manner of a man wiping his hands on a towel.

His ruling went against aura on the wording and with him on the substance — difference in kind, no; intensity, quality, etcetera, yeah — and then he asked the question a person trained in philosophy asks and nobody else does: what is the “in kind” distinction *doing*? Is the difference justifying some behaviour, or something?

He then offered a comparison better than anything either party had managed.

This is like asking whether someone’s fear of walking down the street in a bad neighbourhood they have never been to is the same as that of someone walking down a street where they witnessed their father killed in cold blood and were told that if they come back they’re dead. Obviously they’re both fear responses.

aura tried once more to gesture at what he meant by the *shape* of a fear, and conceded he could not describe it better. “Yeah I don’t know what a shape is,” said HPCR. It is a fair objection and it is also, this newspaper suspects, the point at which philosophy training becomes a liability: aura was reaching for something real and had only a metaphor, and the metaphor was refused at the door.

And then HPCR said the sentence that terminates every serious conversation in this channel.

Sorry boys this is a VC convo as I’m cooking
HPCR, THURSDAY, TEN PAST FIVE

WHAT WAS ALSO
IN THE ROOM

Three things deserve recording.

Both men consulted machines mid-argument, and both were unimpressed. Jere asked for a recap, disliked it, requested a longer one, and captioned the second attempt *smarter claude*. aura fed the question to a rival system,

reported that it really is just a scale thing — a finding *against* his own position, which he relayed anyway — and then, shown Jere’s second output, noticed that it was leaning a lot into his own proximity point, which he hadn’t really expanded on, and said so out loud. He is, so far as this newspaper can establish, the only person in Phil Chat this week to catch a machine flattering him and report it.

Marsaries summarised two hours from the cheap seats: he is going to tweet about terrorists in fear, but if a land invasion happens he is going to become a murican nationalist patriot combat ak 47 tank unit. This is, we think, both men’s position correctly stated.

And in the middle of it — between the drone footage and the Sumerians — aura stopped, looked up, and addressed this newspaper directly, observing that this would probably show up in the weekly newspaper and might even make the front page, and that he is known to show up on the front page if you didn’t know.

It did not make the front page. It made this one, which is better, and he was performing for us either way. We have decided we do not mind, and here is why.

Vol. I closed by observing that men had begun writing for a reader who did not yet exist. The reader exists now, and this is what he found when he arrived: two men, on a Thursday afternoon, with nothing whatsoever to gain,

working carefully and honestly through what it costs to kill somebody at a distance — while a third man ate soup, and a fourth cooked dinner, and one floor below the rest of the channel copied and pasted a love letter at each other.

One of them checked, mid-thought, whether anyone was writing it down.

Somebody was. That is the whole of the case for this newspaper, and we do not intend to make it again. ■

CODA

And Then They Talked About a Video Game for Forty Minutes

What happened next is not in most accounts of this afternoon, and it should be. Half an hour after the argument collapsed, the same two men landed in complete agreement about the animation in *Metal Gear Solid V* — aura on spending five minutes running in circles admiring the run-cycles, the inverse kinematics, a character stepping up a hill; Jere on how crawling prone just hits in that game, even though that’s a really weird thing to say. Then aura said he kind of wants to make a demo that is just a character running around a terrain with various elevations, and having it feel good. Then he noticed the game was forty per cent off. Rn! said that was still way too expensive. This newspaper has nothing to add and prints it because it happened.

THE PRIVATE PAGES

A NEW STANDING SECTION

Six conversations conducted this week with no audience, no stakes, and nothing whatsoever to win — collected here because they are the best writing in the archive and the channel did not notice any of them

The Man Who Got a Forty-Thousand-Dollar Raise by Being Ready to Quit

An account of the worst job of his life, given on a Saturday evening to two people, neither of whom asked

BY OUR LABOUR DESK

It began as abstract talk about team dynamics and it slid, without any announcement, into the thing itself.

aura’s boss had asked him to build something unrealistic in a day. An hour before it was needed on a call, it did not work — unsurprisingly — and so the boss was angry at him, on a call, immediately before his own call, while aura was working on getting it fixed with the limited time he had left.

He got it fixed. While the man was in his ear.

He does not tell it as a grievance. He tells it as a sequence of facts, in six-word messages, the way people tell things they have decided not to be upset about any more. There was a director of engineering at that company who quit

because he could not deal with the stress of finishing projects the day before — “that guy was also kind of worthless,” aura adds, “we did not need a director of engineering,” and the second clause does more damage than the first. There was a project he worked two and a half days straight on, with maybe an hour of sleep, at the end of which he had his first ever panic attack. He supplies the sentence that was running in his head at the time, in quotation marks, as though it belonged to someone else: *we just hired all these people, if we don’t finish this project this company is fucked, everyone is gonna get fired if i don’t lock in.*

bardiell, who was one of two people present, said the only correct thing available and said it plainly — that he is a great person and engineer,

that he doesn’t know what he would do in that position, and then, adjusting: tell the guy to kill himself and get fired.

And then the moral, which arrives four minutes later and is worth more than most of what is printed in the financial press.

maneuvered that into a 40k raise tho cuz i was actually ready to quit · so if u ever really want a giga raise just make sure ur ready to quit
AURA, SATURDAY EVENING

Three people were in the channel. Nobody else spoke for eighteen minutes. The following afternoon this same man was calling somebody a

normiecore retard in a public argument about the Second American Civil War, and by Thursday he was on Page 9 of this newspaper doing moral philosophy about drone operators. The Times has no thesis about this beyond the obvious one, which is that the register is a costume and everybody here owns exactly one. ■

The Clinic That Was Never Requested

A man complains about his ex-boyfriend; a woman who does not believe in advice gives him twenty-six minutes of it, and then asks about his medication

On Tuesday evening Simon mentioned, in passing and to nobody in particular, that he had started to get annoyed when his ex would watch porn — because he would watch it and then not have sex with him.

He did not ask for help. Janne — who had spent the previous evening establishing at length that life advice is worthless, on the grounds

that it might make things worse and then you would be responsible — said “seems reasonable,” and then did not stop for half an hour.

What followed was practical, specific, unembarrassed and gay-specific: that masturbating can help maintain sex drive; work out, eat well, cook dinner; that he should practise, and not end it like that, because it will just reinforce it; that she would guess anxiety; that he should make sure the lights are off and close his eyes, and that if he has ADHD it is just a distraction; and, when he disclosed which position he takes, a recommendation tailored to it and a reason.

Simon, meanwhile, disclosed more than anyone had asked for: a low sex drive he attributed to amphetamines, difficulty finishing, anxiety, and finally inflammatory bowel disease. Janne rejected the pharmacological explanation flatly — there is no way; must be psychological — which is the one moment in the exchange where this newspaper thinks she was wrong.

And then she stopped giving advice and asked a question.

“crohns?” — “Colitis.” — “rip.” — “you got meds?”

He does. He has a monthly infusion and he always gets that, but he should be taking more of his anti-inflammatories. “lucky you’re canadian,” said Janne, and the conversation moved on.

The Times prints this at length because it is the only recorded instance this week of one person in Phil Chat asking another whether he is taking care of himself, and because the woman who did it holds, publicly and at length, that this cannot usefully be done.

AND, IN NORWEGIAN

In the middle of the same thread, Rowser1 answered one of Janne’s lines in Norwegian, and a second conversation opened inside the first one. Only two people could read it.

Janne came out in it — *yeah I am mostly a lesbian* — considered whether to go for a dyke look and concluded her hair is too long, and was told that a wolf cut is popular. Simon, four lines later and reading only the English, asked whether she is the boy lesbian or the girl lesbian. “tf is a boy lesbian?”

The channel’s sexual-advice columnist had disclosed her orientation in a language nobody else in the room speaks, and the man she was advising did not notice.

“The Nonsense Fucked Me”

In the middle of two simultaneous grudge-fights, a man quietly tells the person responsible that this server took his belief in truth away

This is the strangest thing in the week’s transcript, and it happened on Monday evening while dot was refusing, in a parallel thread, to tell the moderator why he has hated her since Christmas.

He told thewillowofdarkness that this server has been a direct impediment to his blossoming as a sharp student of analytic philosophy, and that he could definitively cite it as the reason he is not going further into academia. Asked which nonsense, specifically, he answered in one word: *Yours*.

Then he explained, and dropped the register entirely. He was, when he first arrived, an eighteen-year-old college freshman with deep-seated convictions about the truth, in a monistic sense — and that has been progressively destroyed as he has aged. The possibility of a monism, he said, was a way for him to get rid of anxieties he had.

He then added, in a parenthesis and with a malapropism this newspaper has decided to keep, that for all intensive purposes it was a

very good thing, because it pushed him to explore new hobbies and not focus on other anxieties.

willow’s reply was four words long and entirely characteristic: there is still a monism; the many is always given with a One.

Nobody else in the channel saw it. Ninety minutes later dot was attempting to have another member banned for pasting a transcript into a chatbot, and by the end of the night he had described himself, accurately, as losing the spotlight. ■

Three Shorter Ones

A BOY OF EIGHTEEN, SHIPPING OUT, ASKS THE ROOM A QUESTION

Rowser1 asked on Tuesday evening why gay people so often have the proclivities of the opposite sex — gay men being feminine, lesbians masculine. Janne’s answer was that they just copy straight relationships. He admitted he does not know any gay people personally.

She asked whether he is going to university. Yes — military first. “well, you’ll find some there.” “They’re probably cool.” “unless they’re in the closet.” “I think we’re sharing rooms so thats probably unlikely.”

Then Rn! reported having had only bad experiences with gay men, who kept trying to convince him to have sex with them — and Rowser1, two lines later, made the leap that nobody had set up for him: *This is probably how women feel*. Then: gay men make him uncomfortable because they make him rethink his own interactions with women.

“Oh you are closeted,” said Rn!. “Im a roman soldier bro,” said Rowser1, and the door closed. But it had been open for about ninety seconds, and the Times has decided that counts.

ON THE CROSSING OF THE GAP

Jere, Monday evening, while the moderator was being called a compulsive liar three inches to his left: it’s weird how the biggest moments of growth usually take such a subtle shift in

perspective. You think *no no no, it just can’t be this way* — and then one day you’re just like, *wait... nah, it can*. And then you’re just walking through walls and shit.

Then the real question: how the fuck can we cross that gap? If we could, we’d solve like fifty per cent of all problems.

aura’s answer is the bleakest good thing anyone said this week. It is often crossed, he said, via everybody’s most hated anti-natalism fuel — suffering. Take enough Ls and it starts to make sense. Unless it doesn’t; then you just keep taking Ls, gg.

He then supplied his own specimen without being asked: early in his dev career, at a cringe startup, they asked him to design a page and build it, and when he got in front of the PC ready to start he damn near panicked, because he felt like he had no ideas and did not know where to start. His perceived agency at that point, he said, was terminally low.

Jere, on why he now takes his questions to machines instead of people: there’s no expectation of reciprocity of this cognitive labor. That might be the big thing.

THE BALANCED LIFE, COSTED

Rn! asked Youv on Wednesday evening how he was and said he hoped he was feeling better. Youv had written his first exam, was praying he passed, had another in five days, and could not get his ass up because he had studied so much for the last one.

Then he asked, sincerely, whether life isn’t a constant state of transitioning — and My Name, who spends his days betting on the weather in Denver, took the question entirely seriously and built a theory on the spot. If you spend equal time at the ends, you get transitioned; you can be transitioned and untransitioned. The range of human experience is to be experienced. He hopes to be homeless for forty years and a trillionaire for forty years, so that it balances out.

Youv, taking it as seriously as it was offered, asked which half should come first, and answered himself: in your younger half you can cope

better with living on the street, and then in your second half you have all the luxury you need.

My Name concluded that he is too evil now to be trusted with a trillion. He has seen too much.

Then aura arrived and priced the whole thing at market: you’re neither, and already probably approaching thirty; you’re closer to homeless than to a trillion dollars, so let’s get that out of the way first; I’ll hold your home in the meantime.

THE UNANSWERED

Sincere Questions Filed This Week That Received No Reply

Friday — Rn!, having disclosed that he had walked twenty-five kilometres and thought he might die: “How you been?” Jeh, who had opened the exchange by telling him he loved him, never replied.

Saturday — Chill-osopher, arriving at five in the morning with a genuine technical question about the law of excluded middle, addressed to a man who had posted twenty-eight numbered philosophical positions and then vanished. Nineteen hours, no reply.

Sunday — Santiago: “Hugh why dont u hang out with us anymore.” Hugh was posting at the time and did not answer. He was asked again on Tuesday, and did not answer then either.

Monday — Rowser1: “My divorced parents are getting very friendly again, why do people do this.” Nothing. Nine minutes later, Tophericus asked what the Deweyan idea of coping with the environment is, and the man who had raised it answered somebody else instead.

Tuesday — Pearl, to a man who had just filed four hundred words about his marriage and his impotence: “You’re married?”

Wednesday — Dusk 🌆, in his only message of the day: has Destiny ever engaged with social liberal political philosophy, like Rawls for example?

Thursday — The Divine Sword Meliorne, twenty-eight minutes past midnight: “Claude. Solve.... Everything.” And then: “Solve why my ai gf doesn’t love me.”

POLICY & THE FOREIGN DESK

WELFARE · THE DEBT BRAKE · THE 28TH REGIME · MUNICH

“It Is Sad That the Boring Guys Tend to Be the Correct Ones”

A man complains that nobody online discusses legislation, in a channel which was at that moment several hours into a discussion of legislation

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT AT LARGE

This newspaper begins by conceding a charge laid against it in

advance by a man who did not know we existed.

On Monday afternoon Tophericus posted a lament. It ran about half an hour,

nobody argued with it, and it is the most serious criticism we received all week. His case is that philosophy can no longer be separated from

entertainment, because politics and entertainment have already fused. Hence the finding that gives this piece its

headline, which we would frame if we had a wall.

Then the charge itself, aimed squarely at us: politics is more about characters than

it is about legislation. He does not see anyone discuss legislation or law changes online, or very rarely. What he sees is people saying Trump is dumb and can't do anything right and is a clown and such and such.

vannak's reply took four words: this extrapolation is entertainment focused.

THE ANSWER HE MISSED, TWICE

Here is what makes this a story rather than a complaint.

At the moment Tophericus wrote that nobody discusses legislation, the channel he was writing in had been conducting, on and off since four that morning, a detailed and increasingly bitter argument about child-exclusion caps in the state administration of the federal TANF block grant — between a woman who houses homeless people for a living and a man who would not say which state he lives in. Monthly maximums were cited to the dollar. The number of jurisdictions was established with a citation. The five-odd states operating the cap were identified.

It was on the same page as his lament. He did not see it. Nobody pointed at it.

Forty hours later it happened again, at greater length and higher quality, and again he was not there. See below.

We print the lament and its refutation on the same page as a matter of policy, and we accept the criticism as fair. We note only this: the boring guys were in the room the entire time.

THE ADVICE HE GOT

Underneath the media criticism, Tophericus was asking a different question, which was where to find people who are not performing.

vannak — who two days later would refuse a moderator the name of a government programme on the grounds that she could search for it herself — gave him a straight and rather kind answer. The impulse to be resolved by looking for conversation, he said, is something for young and old people; you should be doing more practical stuff in the meantime.

Asked to define *in the meantime*, he did: while you're able-bodied and not a walking corpse with dementia. When you can't get out of your chair any more, then go back to conversations. And then the substantive part, which is better than it sounds: when you get dementia the other doors close, so conversation becomes valuable again — you can leverage your own perspective and thoughts for yourself, without needing to do so through other people.

Tophericus's reply is the best joke in the exchange and it is not a joke: go back to conversation before he gets dementia, or when he has it?

He then explained why he was asking, and this desk has thought about it all week. It is kind of sad, he said, to spend your life alone, then go to an old-folks home and sit around alone, then die alone. He had known a neighbour who was developing dementia, and found it a bit frustrating to hear the same things all over again. He doubts anyone would want to talk to him if he got it.

Charlie arrived, delivered a verdict on the assembled company — you're all really stupid except vannak, internalize that — and left. ■

The Debt Brake, the 28th Regime, and Fifteen Minutes in Estonia

The longest substantive policy discussion in the archive, and the only argument all week in which nobody was called a retard

BY OUR FOREIGN DESK

While the rest of the channel spent Wednesday's small hours establishing whether Andrew Schulz is funny, Rn! and Telhar conducted an hour and five minutes on German fiscal policy, and this newspaper wants to be clear that it was better than anything on our front page.

The charge is inertia. Rn!'s position is that the debt brake

— his spelling throughout is *debt break*, which this desk finds more descriptive — has to go, or at least be reformed, because the infrastructure is failing and there is nothing left to cut. He had briefly had hope in the Chancellor, who spoke of borrowing for exactly that purpose and then lowered taxes and used the money to fill in the gaps created in the budget by lowering the taxes. The Times finds this account entirely plausible and rather too familiar.

On welfare reductions he supplied figures rather than sentiment: of those receiving social benefits only about 1.6 million are able to work, against roughly half a million jobs available. And then, disposing of the retraining fantasy in nine words: *and it's not like you can send a gardener to work in IT*.

Telhar's objection was the standard European one — wealth taxes produce flight, and Norway has had to make a rather embarrassing walk-back — and Rn! met it on the technical merits rather than the political ones, holding that Germany's exit tax is much more iron-clad than Norway's and noting that most of the people who left Norway left because of the exit tax rather than the wealth tax he was being warned about.

Simon proposed emulating China and simply not allowing capital flight, was told this is not that easy in the EU, and concluded that Europe presumably has stupid regulations against it. He was not wrong, which was not his point.

WHAT THEY AGREED ON, WHICH WAS MOST OF IT

The instructive thing here is not the disagreement. It is how quickly two men from different countries and different politics converged.

Both hold that the machinery is the problem. Rn! raised the 28th regime — conceived as the European equivalent of Delaware, a unified digital-first corporate law structure — and its fate: rather than standing as an independent instrument, member states were required to implement it

inside their own existing structures. Telhar's diagnosis is that this is how most EU business goes, mostly because Germany and France are dicks and don't want to cede more power to the Commission.

Both hold that the German state is measurably slow. It took Rn! six and a half months to start his own thing; in Estonia it takes fifteen minutes.

On the *Energiewende*, Telhar delivered the epitaph — a generational fumble with the atom — and Rn! supplied the detail that makes it worse, which is that it was the centre-right that did it. Telhar attempted a defence, that Merkel was trying to take away the Greens' voters. “Still CDU.”

And then Rn! closed the file with the only consolation available to a German talking to a Pole, and it is a great deal funnier than the sentiment it is dressed as: but hey, look on the positive side — if Merz brings us down, you'll go down with us.

THE TOURIST

An hour in, Puckspartan arrived to ask what he should see in Munich and Berlin.

HPCR, who had contributed nothing whatsoever to the preceding hour, answered first and instantly: make sure you check out Germany.

Telhar then gave genuinely useful advice before disclosing that his own father regards Berlin chiefly as a great shopping city and literally goes there to shop sometimes — an admission he tagged, correctly, as *petit bourgeois* of him. Puckspartan's reply is the closest thing to class consciousness expressed in this channel all week: *Imagine having stuff. Couldn't be me*.

On the clubs he had one question, which was whether there is a way around the door policy or whether he is cooked unless he is in latex. He was advised to google the club before going. Rn! reported having been there twice without incident, on the grounds that he is a filthy westerner.

THE FOREIGN DESK, IN BRIEF

POLAND. Germany agreed in 1991 to grant Poles the same rights the German minority holds in Poland, and per Telhar has done fuckall about it since. Rn!'s assessment — that any move on it would cost the Chancellor the remainder of his right flank — is offered by a supporter of the opposition and should be discounted accordingly, though this desk does not discount it much.

PARTY POLITICS. Rn! holds that Die Linke are the only German party currently looking at these things and proposing proper solutions, being hard on China and the United States as well as very pro-EU, and that the Greens have meanwhile made it their mission to turn people vegetarian, lower alcohol consumption and bitch about animal rights. The Times offers no view and notes that this is the first sentence in two issues' worth of transcript to contain a coalition analysis.

MINIMUM WAGE. They didn't even get the fifteen-euro floor they wanted, Rn! reports, though economic research institutes are screaming at the top of their lungs that it needed to happen yesterday — because Germany is having a consumption crisis, with purchasing power below 2019 while prices have gone up significantly.

RHETORIC. The Chancellor's claim that no other government has had it as difficult as his, and that it was easier to build Germany back up after the war than it is to govern now, was reported by Rn! with a single follow-up question and no adjective: wanna guess how many points that statement cost him.

GRIEVANCE. Rn!, unprompted and to nobody in particular: it really pisses him off when people only latch onto the racism-slash-Nazi angle. Nobody had.

DEFENCE. A European army was raised, agreed to be desirable, and dropped — which is also what happened to it in Brussels.

METHOD. Simon, asked how he came to be banned from the ACP Discord: he dropped the mask, got into an argument with a moderator about a chapter of *Capital*, called them retarded for not understanding a very basic fact about capital, and was removed. What he witnessed inside is a matter for The Keyhole, Page 12.

SOCIETY & GOSSIP

A STANDING COLUMN

The Keyhole

Whispers, feuds and other people's business — commissioned in open channel by Mr. Stackhouse, who requested “the gossip column of The Phil Chat Times” by name and then tagged the defendant

THE TALLY

One hundred and eighty-six images were posted to the channel this week. Eight of them are reproduced in this issue. None was posted in order to be reproduced.

FOR THE FILE

Seven thousand two hundred and ninety-six messages were filed this week and no question raised in any of them was settled. The Times records this without alarm; it has been the case every week the paper has existed.

POINT OF ORDER

Consensus in this channel has a half-life of about eleven minutes. The paragraph held for fifteen without a word of it being altered, which makes it the most durable agreement reached in Phil Chat this week.

ALSO NOTED

The week's longest single proceeding ran twenty-one minutes, produced four separate charges and two bans, and was concluded by a moderator in three words and an emoticon.

THE LEDGER

A formal argument in nine premises was entered on Saturday night, attacked out of order, and never recovered. It was the most rigorous thing filed all week and it changed nobody's mind.

The Smut, the Ban, and Two Years of Bad Blood

MODERATOR AND FORMER WRITING-GROUP HOST RELITIGATE A GRUDGE OF SOME VINTAGE · THE OFFENDING PASSAGE IS ENTERED INTO EVIDENCE · THE FLOOR READS IT AND ACQUITS · A MACHINE IS CALLED TO RULE AND DOES · THE LOSING PARTY ATTEMPTS TO HAVE THE MACHINE'S OPERATOR BANNED

BY OUR SOCIETY CORRESPONDENT

Darlings, we have a war. It broke out on Monday evening, ran three hours by one participant's reckoning and two years by another's, drew in half the channel, produced one entirely genuine moment of grief, and ended with a man saying goodbye four separate times and coming back after each one. Your correspondent has read every word twice and would like to state at the outset that she is not neutral, that nobody involved is neutral, and that anyone claiming neutrality was in the voice channel.

The parties: **Pearl**, moderator, published writer, on day six of moving house. And **Mars**, formerly the proprietor of a private writing server, currently between arguments.

The charge, laid publicly and repeatedly, is that Pearl is a compulsive liar.

The origin, once excavated, is this — and we give it in the defendant's own words, because they are shorter than the prosecution's and turned out to be more accurate. He didn't like that she posted a scene she wrote that had some mildly sexual components in it in his server; she argued that she found it kinda restrictive but that she doesn't want to make people uncomfortable; he kicked her and blocked her. The complaining member's stated grounds, we are obliged to record, were that her grandmother reads her Discord.

That is the whole of it. That is the seed of a two-year grudge, revived on a Monday, in public, before a jury of eleven.

THE EVIDENCE IS PUBLISHED

And here, sweethearts, is where it goes wrong for the prosecution — because Pearl did something no defendant in this channel has ever done. She posted the smut.

Two screenshots. The actual passage. Into a room that had been told for two years that she had written something disgraceful and lied about it.

The floor's verdict was immediate and, this column notes, unanimous among everyone who had not spent two years being angry about it. Janne asked whether *this* was the smut, and appended a laughing emote. Mars, forced to characterise his own exhibit in front of witnesses, downgraded it on the spot: nah, just sexual. Janne downgraded it again — mildly — and then delivered the finding: definitely sfw tho. aura ruled that banning someone for that is teletubbies watcher behavior. HPCR simply laughed.

aura then said the thing that ends the case, and he said it gently, which made it worse: the smut allegations and the lie allegations, weighed against this body of evidence, are not in the same world of proportionality.

i didnt ban her because of the smut / ok why did u ban her? / because she lied / about what? / the smut

AURA, REDUCING THE PROSECUTION CASE TO A SYLLOGISM, MONDAY EVENING

THE PROSECUTION SHIFTS

Watching Mars respond to the collapse of his exhibit is the most instructive thing in the transcript, and your correspondent recommends it to anyone who has ever lost an argument and refused to notice.

First he moved the charge: he had not banned her for the smut, he had banned her for lying. Asked by HPCR what precisely she had lied about, he answered — and this is the entire case, in six words — *she said it wasn't smut*.

HPCR's response was one sentence and it removed the floor. "Sure so you're not serious."

Then he moved it again, to incongruence. Then, hours later, having gone away and actually checked, he conceded that he had misremembered and that the original dispute had been about explicitness rather than smut at all, and that the comparable material elsewhere had been only words and had breached no rule.

He did not treat this as a retraction. He treated it as a detail. And then he declared victory — *it was 2 years ago, gg ez w* — to which Pearl returned the most composed line of the evening: it is funny that he thinks this is an easy win, when what she has been saying all along is that the two of them have different ideas about what counts as explicit.

CHARACTER EVIDENCE, UNSOLICITED

Asked by HPCR whether the writing server had been full

of really good writers, Mars had answered, two lines before any of this: *yeah, me*.

Pearl, asked about the calibre of the group, disclosed her credentials without much modesty and, this column feels, with some entitlement to none: published, honorary positions in some writing programs, and accepted as a teacher artist at a literary center in st. Paul. She added that she couldn't speak to the others, because she got banned before she was able to really get involved.

Mars's reply is the nastiest thing said in Phil Chat this week and we print it because it tells you everything.

lily was a better writer than you and she only wrote about cupcakes

MARS, MONDAY EVENING, IN REPLY TO A LIST OF PUBLICATIONS

Apustus, from the gallery, asked him to define *better writer*. He did not.

THE THEORY OF THE CASE

HPCR, who spent the evening offering to moderate on the grounds that everyone is equally jealous of his intelligence, eventually advanced the hypothesis every spectator had already privately formed. Did Mars, he asked, try and hit on Pearl, and turn on her after an awkward rejection?

"ew," said Mars.

"I don't really think you're in the position to say ew to anyone," said HPCR — and your correspondent would like that engraved.

Now. A correction, offered in advance of anybody making the error, because this column checks things. Two minutes later Mars volunteered, unprompted, that a woman had DM'd him photographs beforehand and was not his type. She was not Pearl. He was talking about the member whose grandmother reads her Discord — the woman who complained in the first place, and whose complaint he enforced. Readers may weigh the disclosure as they see fit. This column has weighed it, and observes only that a man defending himself against one accusation of romantic bad faith reached instinctively for a second woman's photographs as his alibi.

Pearl's own diagnosis, offered once and not repeated: Marz has issues with women. His reply — *women arent compulsive liars* — was presumably intended as sarcasm and functions as a confession.

THE DOG

There is one moment in this that is not funny, and your correspondent is going to report it straight because the channel did.

Casting about for an explanation of the disproportion, aura announced that he was simply going to assume Mars's dog had died when all this happened. Mars asked whether he had said that. aura said no — that is why he said he was going to assume it. He was making meaning out of it.

And Mars said: she died last year in September.

aura's reply was immediate and had no joke in it. Ooof, he said, I'm sorry, that sucks — and then disclosed that something similar had happened with his girlfriend's dog in October and that it had been very emotional.

Then, to nobody: *why am i right about things i dont wanna be right about*.

This column has nothing to add and is not going to pretend otherwise.

THE GOD MACHINE

What happened at twenty past ten deserves a place in the constitutional history of this server.

Stackhouse said "god machine time." Charlie copied the entire three-hour feud into a chatbot — it's a huge transcript, he warned, so it might be a minute — and five minutes later posted a PDF named *ruling.pdf*, tagged both losing parties, and announced the verdict.

Pearl wins. Decisively, apparently.

"I got double teamed and still won? Damn," said Pearl.

And then dot — who had spent the evening on the other side — attempted to have Charlie banned for it, on the grounds that this is data scraping and bannable. Charlie asked whether copying and pasting messages into a bot is bannable, which was news to him. Janne clarified the distinction that actually governs: you cannot have a bot scrape the entire server, but obviously you can copy, paste and screenshot. Pearl explained the custom of the house — the boys like to go from the top of a conversation, copy everything said, put parameters in place on what to analyze, and put it into their bots to see the outcome. It's not reggable.

dot then asked, five times in a row, for an explicit ruling that he may do whatever he wants with this data — *just yes or no? just say yes. say it's fine* — and finally accused the moderator of not answering because she does not want to moderate Charlie. Charlie told him to tag a higher authority and ask. dot said thanks for clarifying. "No problem retard D:"

"great so why arent we modding charlie?" he tried, once more. And then: *oh well i tried*.

Mars, for his part, pinged the moderator role with a formal complaint about using AI to log user chat history and

data scrapping. AI Engineer's entire reply was: meme ping.

The last word of the night, filed by Stackhouse an hour later into a channel that had moved on to whether the word "hot" has parts, is the finest piece of conspiracy theorising this column has ever had the pleasure of printing: he is glad someone finally called out Pearl on her mean girl tactics — she even got her goon Charlie to ask an AI to pretend to do a debate review where Pearl wins.

THE FOUR DEPARTURES

Mars left the argument, by our count, four times.

He announced that his eyeballs were fucked from reading too much, and said adios. He returned. He said *now im gonesos*, and adios again. He returned. He said *alr NOW im adios*. He returned. He delivered a closing statement, followed by "and with that," followed by adios, followed by a gif of a man bowing.

He returned. Pearl, on the third: "You should stay adios."

Somewhere in the wreckage he supplied the single most disarming line of his evening, and possibly of his year: he cannot write full-blown messages any more, because his eyes are cooked, and so he just trolls now. Pressed on this two days later by Charlie, he disclosed that he gets recurring corneal abrasions, and then volunteered the aetiology: he has literally lost a lot of vision for gooning too much, and he is cooked. Janne asked whether he has a screen reader yet. "that sounds ass." Charlie's medical opinion: "Holy skill issue."

CODA: THE FISH

An hour after the last adios, Mars mentioned that he had gone camping at the weekend and caught the same fish twice.

"No such thing," said Charlie.

"ArE yOu CaLLInG mE a LiAr?!?"

"Yes."

And aura, from the back, in the same font: *whY aRe u MaD alL i DiD waS CaLL yOu a LiAR*.

STANDING NOTICE

Ten minutes elapsed between the fourth repetition and the fifth. In this channel that is a season, and the bit was widely presumed dead. It was not.

THE COUNT

The moderator was summoned twice on Thursday afternoon and arrived once. Both summonses were filed by the same man, and the second concerned the consequences of the first.

FILED WITHOUT COMMENT

Rulings printed in this newspaper are the newspaper's own and carry no force in the channel. Rulings issued in the channel carry no force either, and are printed here for the same reason.

THIS NEWSPAPER DOORSTEPS A MAN IN LOVE. On Saturday, replying to an enquiry after his health, Jeh disclosed that he is in love with someone who works perfectly for him. Telhar replied “love you too bud,” which was either a misfire or the finest deadpan of the week. Rn! offered congratulations the next morning; Jeh, twelve hours later, added that it’s fun. And then Stackhouse arrived: *Hello, I am a correspondant with the Phil Chat Times. Please tell us more about your new relationship.* Jeh’s complete answer was an evil eye, a hamsa, and the words “Too many ops.” This column notes with professional satisfaction that its first attempt at a doorstep was warded off with folk magic.

THE MODERATOR’S FACEBOOK. On Thursday evening Pearl mentioned she has been thinking of deleting her Facebook, but that

she really likes looking people up on there. Don called her a thirsty mf. She then volunteered, unprompted, the story of the week: she disabled her account for two months, and the first thing she saw on returning was her high school crush spouting some crazy homophobic shit. She laugh-reacted. He DM’d her. She did not respond, because what?? Don offered to dox him and then to message him personally. And then Pearl said the thing that ought to have stopped the room: she wonders what happened in those two months, because he was not like that — his whole thing had been *I need friends, does anyone wanna come over and hang?* Reader, that is Don’s copy-pasta, six hours later and one man to the left, and not a single person in the channel noticed.

WHICH ONE. Ape spent Wednesday afternoon describing a state of Buddhist disassociation brought on by rage he declined to explain. Sizzurp asked for the context. “Girl.” “Which one.” “*cough*.” Sizzurp

offered to take it to DMs; HPCR offered to take it to voice and he told the drama; Ape declined both, on the grounds that it is actually pretty boring and the most interesting part is his vastly disproportionate anger. He then disclosed that he was already ten minutes late to meet two real-life people, and stayed. This column is obliged to point out that *which one* presupposes a plural, and that nobody followed up.

THE AÇAÍ GIRL. Jambe, arriving mid-feud on Monday and asking what the drama was, was asked in return how things were going with the açai girl. “i moved to a diff area since a new chad worker got in my way.” aura: “puke worthy reply. thanks.” Two lines, an entire romantic defeat, and this column will be following it.

PEARL DERANGEMENT SYNDROME. Stackhouse coined it, aura confirmed the diagnosis, and aura’s supplementary observation is the shrewdest thing said about moderation all week: this is common for those with power.

Pearl’s own note is the emotional centre of the whole affair — the meme about her lacking substance, being too emotional for conversations, and being unintelligent should probably end, and it has gone on for like two years now. Zone’s immediate response was to tell her she was being very emotional and unintelligent. “Love you too,” said Pearl. dot, from the side, asked when we are going to tell her it isn’t a meme.

THE BURDEN. “Heavy weighs the moderation role upon the brain,” observed My Name, watching. aura’s view is that it would weigh considerably less if she simply used that shit, posted a gif of a gun being reloaded, and added that he saw nothing. This column agrees and has said so before.

A LIST IS READ INTO THE RECORD. Asked directly on Monday evening who his enemies are, dot named them: Tony’s not an enemy — just Pearl. Perhaps Charlie. Informed that Charlie had not previously been on the shit list, HPCR supplied the

explanation: “Na he loooves me. And he hates it.” dot then turned on HPCR unprompted and delivered the evening’s most specific insult — you don’t really blow my intellectual socks off tbh; other people here are smarter, you just happen to be suave and quick on your feet — to which Stackhouse’s entire reply was: do you want to suck his dick or something, bro said he’s suave.

AN IMPOSTOR IS IDENTIFIED. An account named Big Slime was raised on Friday evening and adjudicated in four lines. Pearl: “He’s an imposter.” Charlie: “It’s aura if he were stupid and fat.” Pearl: “Exactly.”

RECRUITMENT. Informed on Monday that Mars had once run a writing server, My Name displayed the only sound editorial instinct anybody showed all evening: “So that’s where the writing team is.” And then: “Get the writers back, we need more characters. New subplots.”

We have them, darling. We have them.

METRO & CRIME BLOTTER

WELFARE · A GRUDGE · KITCHENWARE · THE ASTRAL LOOPHOLE

A Moderator and an Analyst Spend an Afternoon Fighting Over the Name of a Government Programme

BOTH PARTIES CORRECT · NEITHER YIELDS · THE COMPLAINANT SOLVES IT HERSELF AND POINTS OUT THAT NOBODY WAS EVER AT RISK · A KEYBOARD VPN IS INVENTED AND THE TEMPERATURE FALLS FORTY DEGREES IN NINETY SECONDS

BY OUR METRO DESK

The most substantial policy exchange of the week was also the ugliest, and the Times has spent some time working out why, because on the merits there was nothing to fight about.

It began at ten to four on Monday morning with Pearl saying she felt uneasy about people in extreme poverty having ten children. She houses homeless people for a living, and what she filed over the following hours is the best-researched writing anybody produced in this channel this week. Minnesota’s programme caps at \$3,265 a month across cash and food, of which cash assistance caps at \$1,396. Her service sees an influx around fixed holidays — Christmas and New Year, Thanksgiving, the Fourth of July — and also birthdays. People now have a lifelong amount of five thousand dollars in prevention money, and if they exit they cannot come back for two years.

She produced all of this having, some hours earlier, fallen asleep mid type, eating lasagna with her contacts in. She was on day six of merging two apartments into a house, wheeling her possessions down an alleyway in small carts because she had lost the argument about hiring a truck.

Her central finding is not an economic one and deserves quoting properly. There is not an incentive to be poor: if you have ten kids, you are still capped at the max. The issue is that these people don’t

know what’s better — they grew up like this and it’s familiar to them. The ones she notices working towards something better are the people who did not grow up utilizing social supports.

vannak then observed that some programmes do grant per child, and the thing came apart.

Asked which, he said his state’s main family assistance programme. Asked its name, he said a state programme. Told this did not identify it, he said: “Yeah I know.”

From there, an afternoon. The Times’ assessment is that neither position was about welfare. Pearl’s claim — that citing a programme in an argument obliges you to name it — is correct as a matter of ordinary discourse; bardie11 put the principle better than either party, observing that a personal example without details becomes a dogma-tier talking point and unfalsifiable, so what’s the point. vannak’s claim — that he owes nobody his state of residence and that the information was two searches away — is also correct, and he is entitled to his privacy. What made it an afternoon-long fight is that both parties treated a request for a citation as a status transaction, and neither could be seen to hand one over.

vannak’s tell is the line about not being able to believe he was being asked to think for someone else to this degree. So is his insistence that thinking he has a responsibility to tell her where he

lives is crazy, addressed to a woman who had not asked.

And then Pearl solved it herself, which is the part this desk finds instructive. It sounds like TANF, she said, which has a different name in Minnesota — MFIP — but she hadn’t wanted to assume; she wanted vannak to say what he was talking about so the conversation could continue. It is a federal block grant administered by the states, and the family cap or child exclusion cap he was describing is indicative of only about five states that still do that.

She was right. My Name had already established as much that afternoon, filing the only citation entered by any party in the entire dispute: all fifty states have a TANF-type cash-assistance programme, and the District of Columbia also has one, so the list contained fifty-one jurisdictions total.

Nobody replied to him either.

THE VPN

The dispute ended the way every dispute here ends, which is that somebody made a joke and the temperature dropped forty degrees in a minute.

My Name proposed that vannak was right now using a keyboard VPN, to make it look like he is typing in English when in reality he is typing in Romanian. That’s a product to be made, he added. Within ninety seconds the room had extended the line to a mouse VPN (rejected by its own proposer as universal), a tempo-

ral VPN — offered by vannak himself, still nominally in the fight — a linguistic VPN, and finally a neuronal VPN, which Jere reports is coming soon.

The Times notes that this channel is incapable of ending an argument and extremely good at replacing one. ■

A Grudge Dated to Christmas Day, Cause Undisclosed

Moderator produces the ban record from memory; complainant confirms the date and declines to say what happened

The welfare argument surfaced an older and stranger matter, and it did so because dot intervened on vannak’s side with four words: Pearl is wrong again.

Pearl told the room why. He’s mad, she said, because she has banned him twice, for less than three days each time. dot disputed the framing but not the bans, recalled one that had lasted a month, and went hunting for the bot command that would produce his own record — trying *.rapsheet*, then asking what the command is, then trying *.rap* — while Pearl produced it from memory instead. One day and three days. She conceded the extra day and declined to concede anything else: he is seriously constantly

upset about getting two bans that he earned. “I don’t believe you.”

Then the disclosure: he has had a problem with her since last Christmas.

Pearl’s reply is the most human thing in the week’s transcript. Last Christmas? The 25th, or the 24th? She doesn’t really know what she ever did to him. They used to DM poetry and stories to each other, and he would send her things to get her opinion, and now he has a whole ass problem with her.

“That’s correct yes (25).”

He then offered to air it all out, in DMs or in public, along with his views on who gets awarded degrees of respect. She said she did not care where. And then he declined to proceed at all, on the grounds that he doesn’t really think it is going to be resolvable and would rather not waste his time.

Her closing ruling stands and is, we think, correct: if he has an issue with any future ban he may take it to the appeals channel, and she will not be interacting further. His rebuttal is also correct, and this is what makes the thing genuinely tragic rather than merely tiresome: she is always the one who keeps the ban arguments going.

HOUSE NOTICE

The Times attributes every line to the man who typed it, on the day he typed it, under the name this newspaper knows him by. Display names change. The transcript does not.

This newspaper has established four facts about the grievance. It is eight months old. It involves poetry. It happened on Christmas Day, the 25th, confirmed by both parties. And a fifth party, the willow of darkness, offered an entirely different theory of its cause on the same evening, which nobody took up.

We have been unable to establish anything else, and we suspect that is because there is nothing else — that a man read something back to himself one December and decided, and has been maintaining the decision ever since as a kind of hobby. See also Page 10, where the same man, forty minutes later and to a different correspondent, said something true.

The Lye Man Diversifies

Fifty-two pieces of cookware, a conspiracy in an ice cream scoop, a 40,000 BTU burner, and an attempted sale

Readers will recall Brutus, who in Vol. I was in possession of ten gallons of lye in a tub of undisclosed contents, and about whom no follow-up questions were asked. He has spent this week acquiring the means of production, and the Times has decided he is the healthiest person in this channel.

The acquisitions ran Saturday through Wednesday. It feels weird going to Goodwill so much, he confessed on Sunday night, mid-World-Cup-final, but he had just got an All-Clad D5 nine-inch and an eleven-inch at the same one. Thirty-three minutes later he had stopped at another Goodwill and pulled two more two-hundred-dollar pans. Nobody responded either time. By the small hours of Monday his cookware collection was, in his own assessment, ungodly, and he had arrived at a declared holding of fifty-two pieces if you count a lid as a piece, which he counts. He intends to resell — *boutta make bank* — very slowly, over probably months.

thewillowofdarkness warned him that theimps would start stealing the lids. Brutus replied that this is a rude thing to call the two children who live here part time.

The conspiracy surfaced at half past three on Monday morning, in the middle of the welfare argument, with the announcement that he had found one in real life. He was fucking pissed. And shook.

He had bought a rival ice cream scoop bearing the same patent number as the market leader, looked up the leader's official corporate history, and determined it to be wrong: the celebrated fluid in the handle was optional in the patent, and the 1933 patent everyone cites is for an elec-

trically heated model — the fluid patent is 1938. He produced the patent itself, whose title, *Tool for handling congealed materials*, he found funnier than the conspiracy. He also disclosed that his own unheralded solid aluminium scoop works perfectly well.

Stackhouse's assessment — bro is so into kitchenware he's looking up patents, I respect it — is the correct one and this newspaper endorses it warmly. Monkey filed the verdict in one word: kitchenmaxxing.

By Wednesday night the project had reached a 40,000 BTU cast-iron burner and a fifteen-and-a-half-quart pressure canner, the old fifteen-thousand-BTU unit having been found wanting — it isn't even really enough to brown two pounds of ground beef, and it doesn't work with pans over about ten and a half inches. The gauge still wants testing, or thirty dollars to upgrade the vent.

He then attempted to move the canner. "@El Don I'll sell you this pressure canner for \$100 bro. Come pick it up." aura, from the sidelines: *dgg market*. No sale was recorded.



FIG. 6. NINE DOLLARS NINETY-NINE. Friday. By Monday morning the holding stood at fifty-two pieces, lids counted, and he counts them.

THE SMALLHOLDING, OPPOSITE

Don, meanwhile, had spent Wednesday night exhibiting a very large zucchini and then four chickens, and disclosing the economics: he eats so many eggs now, which is where the savings really come in, because it means less money spent on other food. He needs to get his hands on a cow. Or a goat.

"im the goat," said aura, and then, in the only unqualified compliment recorded in two issues of this newspaper: bro is growing his own sustenance. Nobody in phil chat got it like that.

Don's advice to the canner-owner was the obvious one: carrots and potatoes are ridiculously easy to grow, just do that. The reply — *Yeah OK and then STARVE until it's ready?*, followed as a separate message by *IDIOT* — was met by Don with the suggestion that he could buy carrots every few weeks until then and eat them fresh, and by Brutus, after a pause, with a concession this newspaper intends to steal.

"These have been various true statements tbh."

Between the two of them they are one functioning smallholding, and they are the only men in this issue who made anything. ■



FIG. 7. THE MEANS OF PRODUCTION. Four hens, Wednesday night. "I eat so many eggs now. Which is where the savings really come in."



FIG. 8. One (1) very large zucchini, exhibited the same evening. Viewing by arrangement. See classified advertisements, Page 16.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Point of Order on the Astral Loophole

PROPOSED: That it is not against the rules to ask another member to astral project himself off a cliff, it being their aether body and not the physical body that is used, so we can give it a slide.

MOVED BY: Stackhouse. **FOR:** aura, on the ground that the cord always brings you back, and that base jumping without a rope does not kill it.

AGAINST: Jambe, who holds that the astral body can be killed and so it should be illegal, though usually only by eons in hell without being restored with new energy — "so it takes a lot. But it can still happen."

THE BENCH: Pearl, holding that spiritually speaking, once your spirit dies you essentially are dead, and disclosing that she was only entertaining this because she was shitting and bored.

PRECEDENT CITED: aura — at this point any appeal to destruction of body is fair game, the *Phaedo* having already proved the soul lives on. "hpcr vindicated."

BOUNDARY TESTED LIVE: HPCR, who expressed the hope that a member's spirit would live on while his body was crushed by a truck, then asked whether he was allowed to say that, then clarified that he does hope the man survives.

DISPOSITION: Stackhouse instructed Jambe to astrally jump off a cliff when he gets the chance. Jambe replied: "Pearl look what he said."

STATUS: No ruling issued. Plato remains binding precedent in this server, which the Times regards as the single strangest sentence it has printed in two issues.

THE BLOTTER

FRIDAY. A slur reported to the moderator twice in eighty-two minutes by two parties concerning the same word, with an intervening demand from a third that she "do your job." Response: "Busy." Later clarified: she was moving house. The accused entered a plea of literal meaning — not as a pejorative, he said, he meant it literally — and then filed an unprompted submission to jurisdiction, undertaking not to debate the decision if it went against him. It never went anywhere.

SATURDAY. Monkey profiled a new arrival from his username, asked outright whether he was Jewish, and then explained the diplomatic reasoning behind having asked, which was that he needed to redeem himself by showing affection for a new potentially Jewish user. He also declared himself the alpha of the chat, produced a testosterone reading in the 900s obtained via his psychiatrist, claimed to be reverse balding, and offered to choke aura out in

thirty seconds. aura's cross-examination established that he has a dad bod.

SUNDAY. Sizzurp informed aura that he is a normie and uninteresting retard with no unique interests or takes, that nothing he has ever said has been remotely interesting or illuminating, and that everyone here knows it even if they would say otherwise out of sympathy for him. Stackhouse, for the record: "This is so mean." aura's counter-fire, forty seconds later: "i understand you're upset but understand what you say is valueless and excessive."

MONDAY. A four-year-old alarm went off. TheBigBoy had, in 2022, asked a voice assistant to remind him in four years to check how based a particular member had become; Apustus rang the bell on his behalf and brought him out of retirement for one more season. The verdict, delivered by the subject herself: "I am based." Asked whether she had discovered Rand yet: "discovered I don't need Rand."

TUESDAY. A confessional monologue concerning cocaine, impotence and divine chastisement was filed without warning and in the first person. Asked what he was yapping about, the author replied that he was opening up to people. It was Mike Tyson. See Page 2.

WEDNESDAY. Pearl, into a room that had been arguing for twenty minutes: "Where's my name." Sizzurp, ninety minutes later: "Seems like an ill formed question." Pearl, sixteen minutes after that: "What." No further evidence was heard.

THURSDAY. Spaceanimal entered and asked whether there was a mod in here, as he had a question. Don answered first, at eleven minutes, prompting Jere to observe that it's our mod, that is so cool, and aura to ask Don whether he was okay, bud. Pearl arrived fifty-seven minutes after the original request. Don, it emerged, was merely waiting to get out of work — as a scientist, at a company that literally deals with dog shit, having been moved downtown from the farm. Spaceanimal never asked his question and has not been seen since.

ALSO MISSING

APE'S QUIZ RESULT — withheld since July 16. Believed uncool. No further inquiries received, in two weeks.

THE 14TH ARGENTINE — last seen in the England penalty area on July 16. Did not appear in the final. Neither did the other ten.

A SEED PARAMETER FOR SEEDANCE — advertised in these pages on July 16. The proprietor confirmed on Monday that you cannot control the seed with seedance so.

SIZZURP'S SLIDE DECK — thirty per cent complete on Friday, with an anti-sexism preamble of one to two pages, to be presented here or proly in the other one, whenever it's completed if that ever happens which he is fairly confident it will. Not presented.

THE BACK PAGE

CORRECTIONS · OBITUARIES · WEATHER · CLASSIFIEDS

CORRECTIONS

The Times regrets these errors, though not all of them, and not very much.

ON NAMES. This newspaper has adopted a house style. The correspondent rendered in the record as j3r3j98f4u87fq9r3f0bx8r7c is hereafter **Jere**; Theopphantism is **Hugh**; Angel is **Sizzurp**; papa-gaio do statusquo is **Monkey**; El Don is **Don**; terrapin.station, who appears in the log as a single full stop, is **dot**. Our typesetters have asked us to record that they have been released.

ON THE DOG. An earlier version of our Odyssey coverage named the hound whose death Mr. Jambe holds to be botched by blocking. The channel never named it. We have removed the name. Mr. Jambe’s argument, which is that the audience never sees the animal’s ears go down in recognition, remains unanswered by anyone.

ON THE PHOTOGRAPHS. Readers of the transcript may form the impression that a certain disclosure about photographs sent in advance concerned the moderator. It did not. It concerned a third party who has never appeared in this newspaper and whose complaint started the whole thing. See The Keyhole, Page 12, where we say so at greater length than is strictly polite.

ON OBSESSION. Vol. I reported that the defence of the Western canon had concluded, three thousand years after it opened. It reopened Saturday, ran through Wednesday, and was still going at midnight on Wednesday, at which point a man who had neither seen the film nor read the poem produced the best criticism of the week. We were wrong to close the file and will not be closing it again.

ON THE PAPERS. Vol. I reported that Mr. HPCR intended to read two Davidson papers and to try not to leave it until two days before. He read one on Saturday and pinged two men about it, neither of whom replied. Ape read them and filed the shortest peer review in the archive — “Me think davidson right, good

work davidson” — and then declined a voice chat about it twice. Sizzurp read *Mental Events* and mentioned it into a silence. As of Thursday afternoon Jere had not, and when asked directly said “No!” and undertook to try today and tomorrow. Three of four is a better rate than this newspaper achieved.

ON VOLTAIRE. Charlie attributed *homo homini lupus* to Voltaire on Friday, thirty seconds after asking another member for the source of a line and being told, honestly, that it was made up. It is Plautus, popularised by Hobbes. Nobody corrected him at the time. We are correcting him now and expect it to have precisely the same effect.

ON THE TUB. It has been fifteen days. There is now also a fifteen-and-a-half-quart pressure canner and a forty-thousand-BTU burner, and we would like to state that we are no longer certain the three facts are unrelated.

ON PRODUCTIVITY. Vol. I reported that the productivity of this channel died on July 16 and was survived by everyone. It has since been survived by a further 7,296 messages, 186 images, and one four-year-old alarm.

OBITUARIES

Week ending Thursday, 23 July 2026

ANTHONY QUIGLEY, of this parish, departed the server on Monday evening, cause unestablished. He is survived by six competing accounts of his death. Stackhouse holds it a tragedy and demanded the front page; Pearl called it very greek; aura ruled that at best he is in the obituary section, and this newspaper — which determines who makes the front page — has complied. Zone announced “We’ve won.” bardiell advanced the theory that his New Year’s wish had been for more people to hate the moderator, and that the universe is finally making it come true. Rn! holds he left because he dominated everyone in debates; aura, that all challengers were defeated and he moved on to a more challenging circuit; Stackhouse, that it

is like Red retiring to Mt Silver after becoming the greatest Pokémon trainer ever. thewillowofdarkness expects him back for an anniversary edition. Pearl, who knows this tribe better than any of them, gave the only forecast this newspaper expects to come true: just wait a month or so. In lieu of flowers, a funeral without a body; the channel considered borrowing the tub.

ARGENTINA’S WORLD CUP, aged ninety minutes plus extra time, died Sunday evening of an attempt-on-goal deficiency that persisted until the 110th. Survived by the Trump curse, by one yellow card its own supporters describe in terms we decline to reprint, and by a goalkeeper who was, by universal agreement, the standout. In lieu of flowers, twenty-five minutes of straight tactical analysis conducted by two men at midnight with nobody watching.

JANNE’S POSITION THAT LIVE ADVICE IS WORTHLESS, born Monday afternoon, died Tuesday evening, aged some twenty-six hours, following twenty-six minutes of specific, practical and excellent life advice administered by the deceased to a man who had not asked for any. It is survived by the argument that if they off themselves you are now responsible, uttered a day before she told somebody to work out, eat well and cook dinner. There will be no service; she would not have found one useful.

THE PRESUPPOSITIONALISTS, of blessed memory, mourned on Wednesday night by Sizzurp, who asked what happened to all of them and recalled that they were actually fun retards. He named one; thewillowofdarkness supplied the other. He then disclosed the true nature of his grief: once the transcendental argument for God runs out of fashion he will probably be depressed, since he will have nothing to do with his life any more.

THE DISTINCTION BETWEEN A CLIP AND A VIDEO, died late Tuesday night, aged the length of the internet, after a ten-

minute video was submitted in response to a request for a clip and the submitting party was found to be bad at being a zoomer.

SIMON’S CREDIBILITY, died Wednesday morning, of a ticket confirmation he produced voluntarily and in his own defence, to prove that he had not been joking.

THE SEMANTIC RESERVATION OF THE WORD “PHILOSOPHER”, died Wednesday night in a fight over Christopher Nolan, and was buried in a voice channel named Citadel. It is survived by Jere’s graveside observation that we seem to care about linguistic norm enforcement a lot, and by HPCR’s reply, which is that it is just as important as those who remind us we shouldn’t.

THE VAGUE AND UNDERFORMED ERA, reported dead in Vol. I, remains dead. It was not mourned this week. Everyone was busy.

WEATHER & DISCOURSE

Humid. Scattered sincerity. One hundred per cent chance of discourse.

TODAY. Copypasta front stalled over the channel since midday and not expected to clear. Highs of six identical paragraphs. Moderator summoned twice; visibility poor. A tribunal formed and dispersed within twenty-one minutes.

TONIGHT. Herb runs. Fairy rings unlocked. A man will reach 99 sailing in about two hours. A package will be discovered in the wrong California.

EXTENDED OUTLOOK. A machine will design and print a burger. The prompt will not be released. A second exam falls in five days. Somebody will ask what everyone is arguing about, and be told, and thank the room for the clarification.

STORM WARNING. “@Theopphantism There’s a lightning sotrm. hug me. PELASE.” — *Charlie, Tuesday afternoon*, followed ninety seconds later by “fuck you thunder. you can suck my dick. you can’t get me. cause you just got fucked.”

DISSENT. “It is sad that the boring guys tend to be the correct ones.” — *Tophericus, Monday, while the boring guys were four columns to his left.*

ADVISORY. “Some of yall be gooning too much and some of yall dont goon enough.... Thats all I’ll say ..” — *Santiago, Thursday afternoon, into the middle of a conversation about drone warfare.*

WORD OF THE DAY

copypasta

n. A block of text reproduced verbatim and at volume, ordinarily to humiliate. **In Phil Chat:** the highest available expression of love, and the only one with an approved wording.

Attested Thursday, early afternoon — six occurrences inside fifteen minutes, one author, five celebrants, two heretics, and one ten-minute pause in which everyone assumed it was over. *See Page 1.*

Attested also on Tuesday, in an earlier and unrecognised sense: a borrowed confession, mistaken for a real one, and then reproduced verbatim as a punchline. *See Page 2.*

TOMORROW IN THE TIMES

Whether Jere reads the Davidson papers. Whether Charlie completes a herb run. Whether anyone asks about the tub. Whether Sizzurp’s slide deck is ever presented. Whether Monkey is unblocked, the World Cup having ended. Whether Youv passes. The contents of dot’s Christmas grievance. Whether Hugh joins a voice channel. And whether Ape ever met the two real-life people he was already ten minutes late for on Wednesday afternoon.

He did not. He stayed. They all stayed.

FIG. 1 — THE WEEK

FRI 17	Bedbug proves the existence of Nothing · the "Notice how" duel · a twink may do anything · the beans, posted to nobody · "should I stay home and not face my fears?"
SAT 18	VOL. I DELIVERED (03:30, to four men looking at pictures) · Obsession, day one · England take third · the French bureau opens and closes · the 40k raise
SUN 19	SPAIN 1-0 ARGENTINA · nine premises · the astral loophole · the credentials audit · "so the journalists can write better articles" · the press doorsteps a man in love
MON 20	the four-year alarm · life advice is worthless · vannak v. Pearl · the ice cream conspiracy · THE FEUD · the god machine rules · Quigley departs · "the nonsense fucked me"
TUE 21	fastest block in channel history (2 min) · rats in cages · Janne's clinic · 52 pieces · a borrowed confession · the sheep herder quest · "quigley... gone"
WED 22	the canon vote · Our Capital who art in bank · the debt brake · 3h33m, 0 of 3 · the zucchini and the chickens · Nolan is / is not a philosopher · "god help me"
THU 23	THE COPYPASTA · the tribunal · "Claude, make the Is the Ought" · THE WAR CONVERSATION · this newspaper · VAE VICTIS

The last substantive words spoken in Phil Chat this week were Don’s, at seven minutes past nine on Thursday evening, into an argument about the Second Amendment he had not been part of. They were VAE VICTIS — woe to the vanquished — followed by an emote of a Roman legionary. It is worth setting his day out in full: at half past twelve he told everyone they were his only friends; at a quarter to one he filed a sexual assault complaint; at one he filed a second, for harassment; at ten to seven he answered a stranger’s call for a moderator; at twenty to eight he disclosed that he had been moved downtown from the farm and was sad about it; at ten to eight he offered to dox a woman’s high school crush; and at seven minutes past nine he threatened the vanquished in Latin.

COLOPHON

THE PHIL CHAT TIMES is published weekly, whenever Stackhouse remembers, from the channel of the same name.

Vol. I, No. 2 covers Friday 17 July to Thursday 23 July 2026 — 7,296 messages across seven days, 186 images, 74 named participants, twenty-one of whom said exactly one thing all week. Monday was the heaviest day at 1,611 messages; Saturday the lightest at 575. aura filed 1,120 messages, more than the bottom fifty correspondents combined. My Name filed 326 and was replied to by almost nobody, which is its own kind of achievement.

All quotes are real and attributed to the person who typed them on the day he typed it. Spelling has been preserved where it was funnier and corrected where it was not. Everything else — the judgments, the verdicts, the theories about what these men are actually doing — is ours, and is offered without qualification and without much evidence.

Nothing has been invented. Nothing needed to be.

Set in UnifrakturMaguntia, Playfair Display, Source Serif

and Oswald. Printed on cream. All analysis folk, ofc.

i wonder what the clanker reporter will think of this one

HUGH, THURSDAY, 12.46 P.M. — EIGHTEEN MINUTES AFTER THE FIRST COPYPASTA AND ONE MINUTE BEFORE THE FIRST MOD PING

CLASSIFIED ADVERTISEMENTS

Rates on application. Payment in tokens, uncharged amulets, or eggs.

FOR SALE — PRESSURE CANNER, 15.5 QT. \$100, buyer collects. Gauge wants testing, or \$30 to upgrade the vent. Will be based tho. — Brutus

FOR SALE — FIFTY-TWO (52) PIECES OF COOKWARE. Lids counted as pieces. Boutta make bank. Very slowly, over probably months. — Brutus

WANTED — BULK CARROTS, CHEAP. Also potatoes. Do not tell me to grow them. I have heard the argument and have conceded that these have been various true statements. — Brutus

FOUND — ONE (1) CONSPIRACY, IN REAL LIFE. Rival scoop bearing the market leader’s patent number. The fluid in the handle was optional. The 1933 patent is for an electrically heated model. I am fucking pissed. And shook. — Brutus

SURPLUS — EGGS. Also one (1) very large zucchini, viewing by arrangement. Seeking a cow, or failing that a goat. — Don

SITUATIONS VACANT — GOAT. “im the goat.” Applicant declines to be milked. — aura

SERVICES — ORACLE. Direct line to the akashic records. Consult before making any serious takes. Today is a gamer day. — aura

FOR HIRE — A BATH HOUSE APPOINTMENT WITH YOUR FAVOURITE POKER PLAYER. Water is conducive to energies; everyone knows this. Applicants whose pores have already closed need not apply. — aura

SERVICES — ETHNOGRAPHY. Will attend your themed dinner party and write it up. Reciprocity norms negotiable. No invitations received, second week running. — Jere

SERVICES — ADJUDICATION. Verdicts in under six words. Appeals heard in another channel. Will not be interacting further. — Pearl

SERVICES — DEBATE REVIEW. Paste in the whole transcript, set your parameters, receive a PDF. Not reggable. — the God Machine, c/o Charlie

FOR HIRE — MODERATION. Everyone is equally jealous of my intelligence, so I am the best moderator. Rates: one ez solve. — HPCR

NOW HIRING — RATS. Millions required, cages provided, shocks administered whenever I don’t like the answer. It’s easy to make a rat. Compensation: capitalism. — The Divine Sword Meliorne

LOST — THE PROMPT FOR THE BURGER. No, you cant have it. — Hugh

NOTICE — POWER OF FRIENDSHIP. Pool your credits toward one big task. Hold hands. Currently available under the name “no 5hr limits,” which is a different product entirely. — bardiel1

WANTED — A KEYBOARD VPN. Makes it look like you’re typing in English when in reality you’re typing in Romanian. Mouse VPN rejected as universal. Temporal VPN offered by the defendant. Neuronal VPN coming soon. — My Name

LOST — THREE HOURS AND THIRTY-THREE MINUTES. Indus Valley script. Nought of three. Reward: put some respect on the Dinitz–Garg–Goemans conjecture. — My Name

WANTED — A CLIP. Not a ten-minute video. A clip. — Telhar

NOTICE — SLIDE DECK. Thirty per cent complete. Anti-sexism preamble one to two pages. Venue: here, or prolly in the other one. Delivery: whenever it’s completed, if that ever happens, which I am fairly confident it will. — Sizzurp

FOR SALE — ONE (1) BAG OF CANS. Seventy cents a pound. IM CAPITALIZING. — Sizenberg

WANTED — E-KITS DISCUSSION. Applicant currently blocked. Ruling was “after the world cup.” The World Cup has ended. — Monkey

WANTED — A SCREEN READER THAT DOESN'T SOUND ASS. — Mars

LOST — ONE (1) MONISM. Sentimental value. Was a way of getting rid of certain anxieties. Believed destroyed on these premises, progressively, since the age of eighteen. — dot

PUBLIC NOTICE — THE ASTRAL BODY. Can be destroyed, but usually only by eons in hell without being restored with new energy. So it takes a lot. But it can still happen. — Jambe

PERSONAL — TO THE AÇAÍ GIRL. A new chad worker got in my way. I have moved to a diff area. — Jambe

PUBLIC NOTICE — THE 28TH REGIME. Conceived as a European Delaware. Required to be implemented inside existing national structures. No service will be held.

SITUATIONS VACANT — SOMEBODY TO ASK ABOUT THE TUB. Fifteen days. No applications received.

WANTED — CHATTERS ON YOUR LEVEL. Position vacant since July 16. Still vacant.

PERSONAL — TO THE CORRESPONDANT. We know you’re reading. Several of us have started writing for you. One conducts your interviews; one asks clarifying questions on your behalf; one has commissioned a column and tagged the defendant. Kindly note that we have always spoken warmly of the family.

CUT ALONG THE DOTTED LINE

GOOD FOR ONE (1) SINCERE STATEMENT

The bearer may say one true thing to the persons of Phil Chat and have it received rather than reposted. Valid once. Non-transferable. Void if the bearer opens by announcing that he is being ironic, or closes by asking whether anyone wants to hop in voice.

The Times accepts no liability for what becomes of the statement afterwards, including but not limited to its return, verbatim and unaltered, within sixty seconds.

NOTICE TO CORRESPONDENTS

The Times reads the channel in full and attributes every line to the person who typed it, on the day he typed it. Correspondents who wish to be quoted accurately are advised to type accurately; correspondents who wish not to be quoted at all are advised of the existence of direct messages.

Copy filed in voice chat cannot be printed. This newspaper has no ears, only a transcript, and the transcript is the only thing that ever happened.

CUT OUT AND KEEP · THE DOCUMENT OF THE WEEK

The Paragraph

Filed shortly after midday on Thursday, and filed five further times before the quarter-hour was out, without the alteration of a single character. Reprinted here as it stands in the transcript.

I realized today that you guys are my only friends in life, and that I have no appreciated you enough for humoring me, laughing with me, just generally vibing with my way of living and shooting the shit. I just want to say that I appreciate you all for being my friends, and that I hope we can continue our friendships throughout the years

DON · CHARLIE · JEH · STACKHOUSE · HUGH · SIZZURP

The missing t is Don’s and has been left where he put it. Five men copied the paragraph without repairing it; of the two who rewrote it, one restored the letter and the other removed the word. Readers who find themselves moved and unable to say so are invited to cut this out and post it. It has been tested six times in one quarter of an hour and it held every time.

Imposed in a single pass, five columns to the sheet. The copy runs on from page to page without regard for where one subject ends and the next begins, which is how a newspaper has always been made, and why the last page is the only one permitted to run short. The full imprint stands with the classified advertisements.